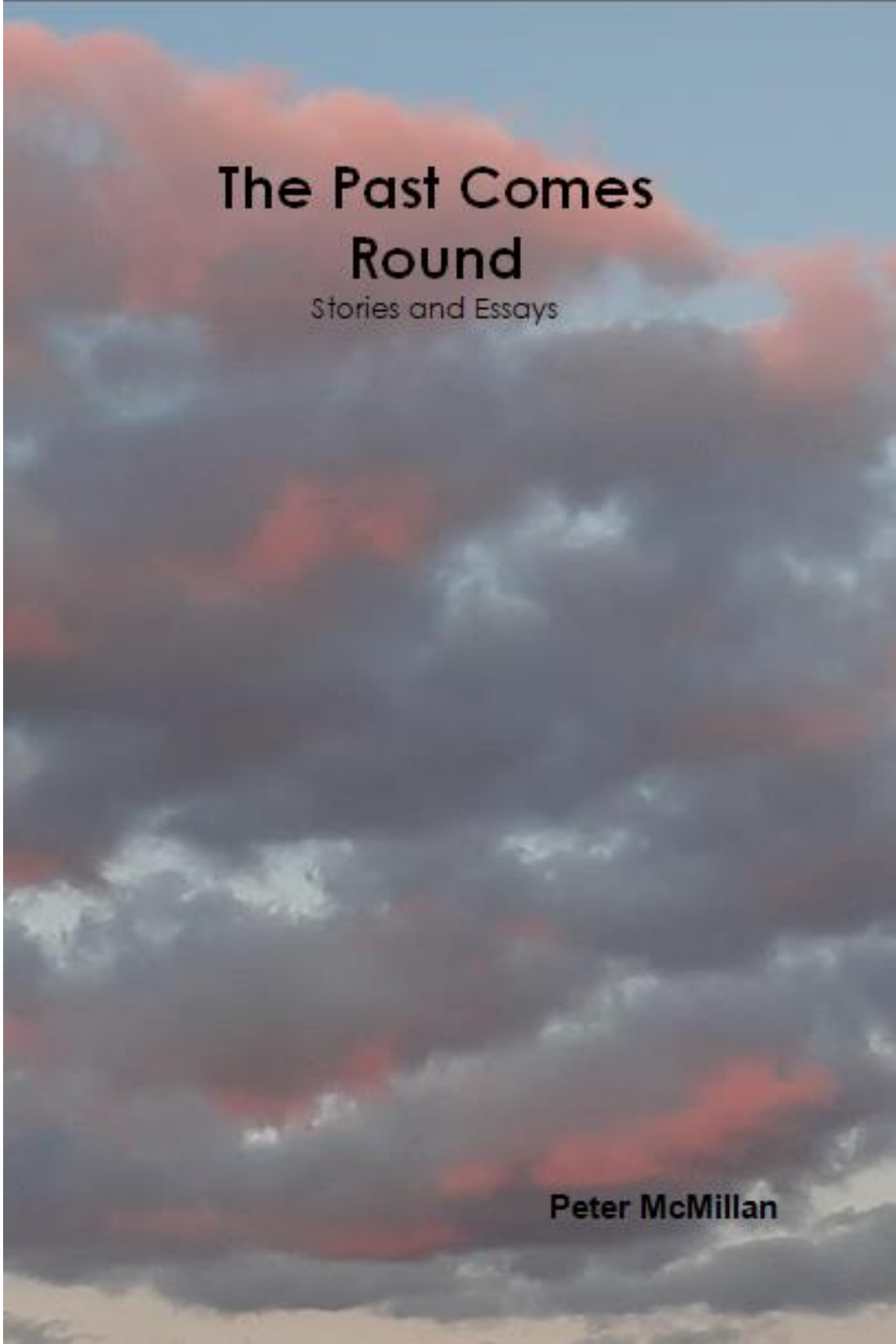

The Past Comes Round
Stories and Essays
Peter McMillan

Books Published by the Author

Flash! Fiction (2012) by Peter McMillan

Flash! Fiction 2 (2013) by Peter McMillan with Adam Mac

Flash! Fiction 3 (2014) by Peter McMillan with Adam Mac

Flash! Fiction 4 (2015) by Peter McMillan with Adam Mac

Flash! Fiction 5 (2017) by Peter McMillan with Adam Mac

An Anthology of Hardly 20/20 Flash! Fiction (2020) by Peter McMillan with Adam Mac

Missing Stories: An Anthology of Hardly 20/20 Flash! Fiction (2020) by Peter McMillan & Adam Mac, Maku Miran (ed.)

Collected Essays on Political Economy and Wartime Civil Liberties, 2002-2008 (2020) by Peter McMillan

Willowing Skywardly: Stories and Essays (2022) by Peter McMillan

Flash! Fiction: Around the Block (2022) by Peter McMillan

Writings Near the End of the Human Era (2023) by Peter McMillan

eclipsed: selected Writings of Fiction and Nonfiction (2024) by Peter McMillan

Artifacts of a Troubled and Troublesome Species (2025) by Peter McMillan

2026

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Peter McMillan, 2026

Dedication

For the students

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Introduction

There are two parts to this book: one of 13 short stories and one of 12 book commentaries. The stories are quick reads and leave some room for the reader to make their own imprint. If the essays have anything in common, it's the distrust of entrenched power.

Fiction and nonfiction don't usually get anthologized together, but I think the two can sometimes complement one another.

A second reason for combining fiction and nonfiction is that it gives the book some bulk, but since each piece can be read independently of all the rest, there's no binding commitment on the reader to heed the 50/50 reading rule.

Third, one part of the book may be of interest but not the other. History, politics and all that aren't everyone's thing. On the other hand, there are times when you prefer something that takes a bit more time to read, say, longer than it takes to have a smoke.

In closing, here are two websites where you can download/read from a much larger library than most of us have access to: Internet Archive and Anna's Archive. Both are nonprofit operations that promote free and widespread access to digitized knowledge. All of my books are on the Internet Archive, and most are also currently available through the shadow libraries searchable from Anna's Archive.

Peter McMillan
Oakville
April 2026

PART ONE—FICTION

WOMAN *in black suit*: Why'd you postpone?
TIM: Been under the weather. This is the first time I'm out of the house since last Thursday.

WOMAN: So, who's walking the dog?
TIM: Neighbor across the street.

WOMAN: Is that Kemp . . . the CPA?
TIM: Yeah. I've known him for 28 years. Good guy. Goes to our church.

WOMAN: Isn't he the cripp—
TIM: Handicapped, yeah. Walks with a limp but gets around well enough. And he loves Pepper.

WOMAN: That's your dog, right?
TIM: Black lab.

WOMAN: So, why'd you call the meet?
TIM: That family I was telling you about last time . . . the one on Sunrise, a couple of blocks over. Turns out they're from Spain.

WOMAN: How do you know that?
TIM: One of their kids goes to the same school as my daughter. She said she'd heard the other kids say he's Mexican.

WOMAN: Why?
TIM: It's kinda strange, cause he's got blond hair and blue eyes. I've seen the woman and she's blond and blue-eyed, too. And my daughter who knows a little Spanish overheard the boy speaking on his cell phone one day, but he spoke so fast it was difficult for her to follow. That's when he told her he's from Spain.

WOMAN: So, what's this new information you have about these people?
TIM: Well, the reason I've been keeping an eye on them is that they have a lot of visitors . . . people who really could pass for Mexicans.

WOMAN: Aren't there a lot of Latino families in your area?
TIM: Not in our neighborhood. They're mostly downtown.

WOMAN: Alright, Tim, get to the point. Explain to me why you think this is important.
TIM: I was getting to that. You see, I picked up a brochure that one of the visitors dropped. It was Spanish, but when I looked at the other side, it was English.

WOMAN: Did you bring it with you?
TIM: No.

WOMAN: Why not?
TIM: I was so nervous about the meet, I forgot it. It's in my office at home.

WOMAN: Tell me what you read, Tim.
TIM: It was this 'Know Your Rights' stuff and it mentioned a couple of dates and locations, but it didn't explain their significance.

WOMAN: Do you remember the dates and places?
TIM: I think one was the elementary school where my daughter goes and it was sometime in early September. I don't remember the exact day.

WOMAN: But you said that there weren't many Latinos in your neighborhood.
TIM: Oh, yeah. A lot them get bused in because the schools downtown are overcrowded.

WOMAN: And besides this elementary school, what else can you remember?
TIM: There was the community center. Oakdale Community Center. It's near Central Library.

WOMAN: And the date?
TIM: It was, uh, a day before or a day after the other one.

WOMAN: So, also early September?
TIM: Yeah.

Woman pulling a brochure out of her briefcase.

WOMAN: Is this the brochure?

Tim turning it over and reading.

TIM: Yeah, that's it. Umh, so you already know about this, why are you interested—
WOMAN: We have to find who's distributing this material.

TIM: Is it illegal?
WOMAN: That's classified. Don't be alarmed. Tim, you're a patriot. That's why we need you. Now, I need you to record all of the license plates going in and coming out of that property.

TIM: But—
WOMAN: This is about national security, Tim. You don't want to let your country down, do you?

Tim hadn't smoked in more than 10 years, but on the way home he bought a pack of cigarettes and smoked the first three standing outside his car.
TIM: Honey, I'm back if you need to use the car.

MARGARET: It’s OK. I caught a ride with Julia.

TIM: Who’s Julia?
MARGARET: Oh, she’s our new neighbor. Not exactly next door. They live on Sunrise. I met her this morning while I was walking Pepper. Mr. Kemp wasn’t feeling well. She’s lovely and so’s their son. Cynthia knows him.

TIM: On Sunrise?
MARGARET: Yeah. You’ve probably met them on your walks.

TIM: Uh, no. I’ve never seen them to talk to them.
MARGARET: Well, Saturday night they’ve invited us for dinner, so you’ll get to catch up then.

TIM: Saturday?
MARGARET: We’re not doing anything, are we?

Sniffs the Tim’s clothes.

MARGARET: Good God! Tim. Did you start smoking again?

I must've dozed off again.

She's relaxed and sleeping now. The morphine drip is finally working. That was horrible!

How could I have said such a thing?

“I'm a scientist, so I can fully understand that the doctor has a lot to consider when he decides how much morphine your mother should be getting.”

What a callous son of a—

Just half an hour ago, Jessi was screaming in pain, begging for something to stop it. I was running down the hall to the nurse's desk screaming, “Morphine! She needs morphine, NOW!”

That wasn't very dignified of YOU, Professor!

The sight of someone you love in excruciating pain—their body clenched like a tight fist—that will recalibrate your feelings in a heartbeat. To hell with logical fortitude.

I didn't care about protocols, I just wanted the goddamn morphine drip and I wanted it IMMEDIATELY. "I'll be there in a minute" wasn't going to cut it.

I've seen my wife in pain before. I was in the delivery room when both of our children were born. The doctor actually asked if she had pain insensitivity. I said, "No, but if you hurt her, she'll hit you." The nurse laughed.

But this, this cancer pain . . . . No, I wish she were insensitive to pain. Thank God the kids haven't seen their mother suffer this bad. Losing—

That'll be hard enough . . . for all of us.

God Almighty! Did I really say that? No wonder we're no longer invited to Sam's cottage. Jesus! I wouldn't either. Ass!

Takes a deep, deep breath.

End of Summer (August 2025)

If you're listening, the cicadas will tell you the season. The crickets will give you the time of day. Lightning bugs can't tell you much of anything anymore. On such a quiet day at the end of the summer when most of the neighbourhood is away, people noise seems to get drowned out by nature.

It's early evening in one of the last hot days of summer. In the twilight, thin pinkish-orange lines contrails mark up the sky like an Etch a Sketch, morphing into strange geometries and exploding into streams of pastel cotton candy as they float by. Hundreds, no, probably thousands of people are up there floating past on their way to or from YYZ.

Our bench faces due west, looking out over a two-hectare field of manicured turf. On soccer field #1, a few left-behind kids are practicing penalty kicks, only one of them brave enough to be the keeper. The dog whines to be let off leash, but she has a taste for what is but shouldn't be left behind—so, "No way." There's just one little fellow on soccer field #2, but he's deftly managing the air traffic of two drones all on his own. His peers over on #1 keep an eye out for stray maneuvers, intentional not. From the north, the early evening tennis "Faults" mix in with the kickers' F-word frustrations, at times in an alternating rhythm.

As the last of twilight fades, our days continuously shortening, the lumpy escarpment of spruces and maples on the far side of the soccer pitches silhouettes the final stages of the day. Moving ever so slowly, the scattered cirrostratus clouds float towards the top of the dome of the sky.

In the dark, on the way home, the air is redolent with the overripe smell of August's unwanted crabapples that squish juicily underfoot.

It’s a sad smell that jars with the season of Thanksgiving that’s just a month-and-a-half away. Further on, in one of the narrow walkways that leads out of the park, the rotting, fruity smell is thoroughly erased by the scent of skunk, now familiar to the dog, so we’re both eager to quickly scoot through the laneway and out into the cul-de-sac.

Halfway home, the sounds of a late summer party greet us just as we turn onto one of the roads leading through the MacMansion quarter. There’s boisterous singing coming from the backyard. Seems relatively good-natured and harmless, but if you live next door it might make you think of a celebration after a rugby match.

Once home, there’s one last port of call for the dog. That gets hurried along at the sound of a mouse trap snapping shut. Then comes the more worrying sound of a wire being pulled through the hedge. Seconds later, a window slams shut.

Somewhere on the return home from Japan, there is a small barnboard store right out in the middle of the desert. There is one long two-lane highway running through the hot white sands, and this little shop is the only sign of life along that gray ribbon of road.

Inside it is dark and cool. The proprietress is an elderly Japanese woman who is wearing a kimono, probably a very colorful one if seen in daylight. She is very polite—I can't imagine her any other way. She must have spoken a little English and my parents spoke a little Japanese. Whatever it is that they must have said, I can't say. At that age, I wouldn't have understood much English or Japanese, and besides, it's the old woman who my mind focuses on.

She has a kindly face. I remember that. And it's dark brown and heavily wrinkled. I'm sure of that, too. To this day, I've never figured out quite how she ended up in the desert in the American southwest. But there she is.

I'd never been in a desert before and its great emptiness is something foreign to me. From the outside, the building has the look of an old general store, but not inside. Inside it feels like home; familiar to sight and touch are the black lacquered vases, tatami mats, translucent folding screens and woodblock prints. Only in later reflections do I add these article names.

While it also appears to be the old woman's home, there are attractions for passersby, although there probably aren't too many. In the darkened front room, the sun is kept at bay by the closed wooden shutters and there is an unexpected coolness in the stillness. Treasures Japanesy are carefully displayed on dark wooden shelves rising to the ceiling. It's overwhelming and much too much to browse through. Besides, the old second-hand yellow

Plymouth station wagon is already overloaded inside and on top. There's no more room for anymore souvenirs—for any of us.

But one item always catches my eye—a piece of wood carved by hand showing hikers on a path that spirals up a mountain. Of all the riches in that room, that's the one I visualize most clearly. I'm in awe of someone who could have shaped a piece of wood into such an intricate scene. It isn't a toy for the hands. It's a toy for the imagination. Ordinarily, it would've escaped my attention.

We got back into the car, and looking back, as best I can remember, we didn't even get milky candy, seaweed crackers or any other goodies for our trip. Funny, but I don't remember much more about our trip. I have no distinct memory of my parents and my sisters and brother at that stop—not like the vivid memory I have of the old Japanese woman and her general store.

There were seven of us and Momma and Daddy were driving us cross-country to get to our new home. We'd already crossed the Pacific and it had taken weeks, it seemed. Now we were on land, our new used car was much, much smaller and more crowded than the ship and seemed to move a whole lot faster, too. My brother made fun of me for years because I got carsick.

For them, it was just coming home. But this wasn't home to me. I'd never been here before. We'd lived in a lot of places, and I don't remember a single one of them. Sasebo, Fukuoka, Nagasaki. These are the names I now know from the stories I've heard, but for me, there's nothing of my own memory I can attach to the names.

Do you remember when you first learned that America had once destroyed these cities? It was years later. You said you weren't convinced by the explanation you were given. It was all kind of fuzzy and dark in a menacing way. You said you felt sort of that

way about the long Vietnam War. No one knew when it would end—if it would end. You said that you used to worry that your older brother would get drafted and wouldn't come home. That he would be included in one of the nightly news body counts.

It took a long time for us to collect everything we'd shipped and it seemed like there was always something new coming out of the trunks. It was like mini-Japanese Christmases. One day, my Daddy brought out of wood carving from one of the trunk. It was an 8-inch birch branch with three hikers on a path that spiraled up the mountain. A memory stirred and I thought back to the old Japanese woman and her treasure house. This looked just like what I remember seeing in her store.

Daddy put it on the Japanese nesting tables in the living room, and told me that this was not a toy for the hands. It was a toy for the imagination. I could play with it but C-A-R-E-F-U-L-L-Y. For months, I did just that. I could spend all afternoon looking at the carving, wondering what these figures would find at the top. Maybe a pagoda-style temple? A 360-degree view of the green forests and valleys below? Or maybe just the thick mist of low-hanging clouds? And wondering how talented the artist must have been to carve such intricate figures from one piece of a birch limb.

All things pass out of favour during the life of a child and this was no exception. Friends, school, church, sports—not necessarily in that order—drew me into a ever-changing and expanding world. The carving got replaced in the living room and went into storage somewhere. I didn't think of it again for many years.

After my parents passed, the sculpture returned. Going through my parents' things, my sisters rediscovered it. There was a brief note from Mom. She had left it to me, knowing how fond I'd been of it when I was a kid.

Among all the other artifacts they collected during their life in Japan, this is the piece that connects most with me. It and the memory of the old woman in the desert store are my sole connections with my very short life in Japan. Even the slides in which I was included fail to trigger any memories. My sense of having missed out on an important part of family history really used to come home to me during times of reminiscing. And this was especially so when we were all together at Christmas and got to the point in the caroling where everyone would sing in Japanese. Almost everyone.

Yet, you still have this one choice artifact and a memory of the old Japanese woman in the small, dark store all alone in the great desert. Whether your recollection is accurate or an artificial composite of many memories, does it really matter? Over the years, hasn't it served you well?

“He who laughs, laughs his last laugh,” and so the sentence was executed on the spot.

In the capital of the realm of Ötarkh, the communities that spiraled out from the centre were for all practical purposes islands. They were as distant from one another as if they were miles and miles apart with no easy access. On ascension, Ötarkh, the self-proclaimed Great Polymath, had razed the outskirts of the ancient city and redesigned his subjects’ habitation to resemble elliptical spirals radiating out from the centre with only one connection and that to the omphalos. Each spiral community was a separate demesne with one way in and one way out. Mostly self-sufficient, the inhabitants rarely needed to travel beyond their own community. And when they did, they were required to pass the peacemakers who managed ingress and egress.

This was Ötarkh’s genius—the creation of an ornately laid out imperial city that most effectively projected his power over his millions. Housing and commercial buildings were short and squat, nothing over two storeys. This, to accentuate the grandeur of the palace and its extensive grounds that seemed to float above the imperial city. It was the pride of his empire. But Ötarkh had also spent his long reign drawing and redrawing colourful maps of his entire land, partitioning town and hinterland to reward his devotees and marginalize subversives and rivals.

Among his eccentricities, the most striking was his immoderate aversion to the sound of laughter. It was said that his only sibling, an older brother, Elvin, who mysteriously disappeared prior to Ötarkh’s ascendancy, had terrorized the young Ötarkh to the point that the boy had nearly lost his wits. The most wicked laughter that would freeze the blood of the grimmest peacemaker accompanied

the boy's daily beatings and torture. To this day, laughter is forbidden throughout the land. It matters not whether it is with gaiety and happiness, laughter, however manifest, earns the death sentence. Officially, those in court maintain that it is an affront to the dignity of the person and office of the emperor.

Among those who were designated to live in the spirals, none were remarkable in any way imaginable. Wealth, certainly not. Just bare sustenance was ephemeral and unpredictable for most. Intelligence, none stood out, and many of the duller majority were recruited to tend the grounds of the palace. Virtuosity in the arts or music; again, none could be found. Such extravagance! Good looks—not for long as those so blessed were snatched away as soon as the palace took notice. While these were not clever, they were pleasant to look at.

And so, a peddler of trinkets and charms and assorted trivialities and frivolities would be born, live and die in obscurity. A common lot for all who lived beyond the court. In ushering the peddler into this story, there is really no need to provide a name, but for convenience, he will be referred to as Anon.

As was the case with all peddlers, Anon was an itinerant trader, this being the most polite description that would ever pass the lips of subjects and peacemakers. His merchandise comprised small vials stored away in deep pockets on the inside of his shabby overcoat. The ampoules appeared to be empty yet each was carefully labeled in a long-forgotten script. Of course, the peddler could read the script or at least remember what it said, or so he professed to his skeptical customers.

In these transparent little bottles was the most dangerous commodity in all Ötarkh's kingdom. Laughter. Anon carried on his person the laughter of many, some from the present and some from

those now deceased. How he came by bottled laughter was not widely known, but no matter. The credulous still believed and optimists still hoped that laughter had not been completely silenced. The few who could confirm that these tiny vials contained what Anon said they did never admitted it. For to admit it would be to invite a most brutal interrogation by the peacemakers. And so, even a whisper was popularly thought to bring down a curse.

Now, Anon and others in his trade had developed the art of rendering themselves invisible. It was by these means that they were able to move relatively freely from one of the empire's cochlear canals to another, trading their wares for whatever might obtain a profitable exchange elsewhere. But it was risky in the extreme. To be caught was to be summarily executed, then and there. The peacemakers were merciless and they enjoyed their work. It was, among them, a point of honour to always be busy.

Anon’s was a particularly precarious existence as the slightest hint that he was dealing in laughter would have brought not just sudden death but the most unimaginable horrors of torture by men and women whose lust for blood and violence was never sated. Needless to say, Anon had a corner on the perilous laughter market.

And so it was that Anon with the stoppered laughter wound his way through one helical subdivision after another. His goods were not those of conspicuous consumption. Quite the contrary, a consumer could only enjoy their precious decanted laughter after sound-proofing a tiny partition of their compact efficiency. Carelessness could result in laughter escaping to the adjacent flats and once done, the peacemakers would be called in to haul off both buyer and seller. This had happened at least once to the peddler’s knowledge. It had led to the confiscation of a lifetime's collection of laughter. And, of course, the permanent disappearance of the

purveyor. A deep bitterness grew up in the furtive company of his fellows.

Anon, himself, had his own grievances. He was the heir of family Anon's laughters—these men, father and grandfather, had been assiduous in secrecy and, well, just plain lucky. Grandfather Anon, as a young roustabout and prankster, had opened a vial of the most effusive and joyful laughter during a circus performance back in the day when circuses were still permitted. On and on the laughter lasted, echoing throughout the building reaching every corner of the pavilion. In the mad stampede to exit the facility before the peacemakers burst in, Grandfather Anon dropped the vial on the ground. It was instantly ground into glass particles by the heavy tread of the frantic spectators. Not a sliver or spall remained . . . else Anon would never have been born. Many died that day.

Grandfather Anon, during the slightly more liberal reign of Elvin's and Ötarkh's father, had weaseled his way into the company of the young Elvin. Elvin was a notorious profligate who traveled with a large entourage of the well-bred and ill-bred, riotously drinking and whoremongering throughout the realm. There was more than a touch of vengeance in Grandfather Anon's motives, and peddler by birthright and fate, he was always alert to opportunity. It was in this company that he perfected the dark art of decanting laughter from the ambient.

Of the vials that had been bequeathed him, one was prized above all the rest. Its magical content had passed into a third generation of Anons. As the last of his kin, Anon had become its keeper. For those brave enough to purchase one of the vials and live, the promise of laughter's return was not just an apocryphal tale, a fancy of idle fools. It was hope itself. However, only Anon knew the contents of this special vial. It was Elvin's laughter—Elvin, the older brother of the man who had become Ötarkh.

The vial's destiny could be said to have been fixed by Grandfather, but it had been accepted by son and grandson. Hidden deep in their souls was a longing for an unknown something. This tiny vial contained the future. It was only to be opened in the presence of Ötarkh who would be driven mad by the evil laugh that had tormented him as a youth. The responsibility for emptying the vial would rest with the one who finally figured out to get close enough for the last laugh.

Whether one act of retribution would change the course of history was a gamble. And whether the future would be an improvement, an even madder gamble. Nevertheless—

Christmas Eve *aeternus est* (December 2025)

"Your mother's got no snow this year. I can't remember when there was no snow on the ground up here at Christmas."

Strange driving up and not seeing any snow—not even dirty snow. Not complaining. We sure had plenty of it in November—more than I can remember and that goes way back pre-climate change era. Lucky we had a few days above zero, because we get a mountain of leaves and we nearly missed the last fall leaf pickup. That's a slimy mess to clean up in the spring and sometimes doesn't get done until summer.

"Damn! We're too late. She's taken the only parking space."

"Well, she does have the kids and presents to unload. Like every year for the last, what is it now, 28 years?"

"You drop me off and unload the food. Maybe someone can stand at the door and take it as you bring it up from the car. I've got to go see Mom. She may be freaking out even though Sister's been here all afternoon taking care of the ducks."

Brother-in-Law's at the door. He's not the 'Armed and Hammered' guy I first met. Definitely more laid back since going native in the hinterland hours away from us and the rest of the world. Tall and lanky, and, naturally, bearded, he's muscular and doesn't have any trouble hauling stuff up the two flights of stairs to the kitchen.

"Merry Christmas!"

"Merry Christmas!" he answers

We get the update. Ducks are cooked. Just have to heat up the side dishes. But there's a whole stack of them that we brought from home.

Hellos and Merry Christmases all around. While the kids are having their *tête-à-tête* in the living room below, the adults look after the food and drink. BOFG—Big Old Fat Guy, self-described outsider and critic of all things not ME—takes some belatedly-purchased snacks down to the living room. Grandma follows making her way downstairs from the kitchen, clutching at whatever support she can find along the way, including grandchildren.

Again this year, there's no music. Father-in-Law had a beautiful stereo system and had collected a lot of choice classical and jazz music over the years. Ever since his passing though it's been hit or miss with music at Christmas. Tonight, Brother-in-Law says the system sparked and popped and gave up the ghost once and for all. It is suggested, and not *sotto voce*, that dust buildup might have contributed to the death of music. *C'est dommage*. And I really mean that because Christmas carols were a big part of my growing up years, though we didn't have piped-in music back then. After opening presents, we used to gather around the piano and sing with great enthusiasm. It was good enough for us. We had generous standards.

The candied peanuts are a hit with Grandma. "You know, I have some every afternoon. They last a long time. I still have half a tin," she says and then shares the details of how she portions them out along with her daily chocolate quota to go with her afternoon coffee. She says that her doctor appreciates the discipline and praises her up and down. Meanwhile, Brother-in-Law's girlfriend seems to be enjoying the chips and dip, though by this hour it may be ravenous hunger. Even though we were later than late, it wasn't such a bad idea to have picked up some snacks on the way even though we

had to stand in line 20 minutes at the drugstore—the only thing open besides the gas station and a convenience store. Everything else shuttered for Christmas.

The kids haven't seen one another since August, so they're completely absorbed in one another's life story updates. Grandma and I exchange nonverbal greetings, equally attentive for any promising noises from the kitchen.

Brother-in-Law's partner is an authentic nonconformist. She speaks freely and without pretension. Occasionally relates a shocker that raises eyebrows—something like switching the price tags on frozen turkeys. But she's really quite likable and interesting. Tonight we learn that she was a bike courier in the city in the days before GPS. That gets Nephew's attention. He's doing the bike courier thing for take-out food—nothing serious, just a lark. There's so much money in trust for these kids; they're not bound by the obsession that drives their peers to be overachievers. Although Niece has surprised us as she navigates the early stages of a professional career. Still, she knows full well that while she's on a tightrope, it's not too far from the ground.

"*Essen*!"

We're summoned to the dining room adjacent to the kitchen. It takes a few minutes to decide who goes where. Why? It's pretty much the same year after year. It's the sense that the dining room shrinks a little bit every year. That and a few of us seem to be larger than the year before. There are eight of us, and the table seats six almost comfortably—four is ideal. At dinner, we're the very picture of a close family.

This year, there's no grace. Nephew is still distractedly speaking privately with Niece. In my head, my *'gratiarum actio*' is most sincere.

Though not as greedy as my family during Christmas feeding, there's certainly no lack of appetite at our table. Auntee, my wife, is a good cook. Better than my mom, not that I didn't always clean my plate at home and ask for seconds when there were any to be had. The meal goes well—maybe too well, because toward the end I feel compelled to declare, "All the food on this table was prepared by my wife (your daughter, sister, Auntee) and she spent all day in the kitchen yesterday cooking all these delicious foods. And the same was true last year despite recovering from three cancer operations."

I'd rehearsed my lines and intended to deliver them after grace, but I wasn't given a segue, so I had to squeeze it in somewhere. It was awkward. Initially, the response I observed reminded me of cows munching away in the pastureland. But then there were a few hesitant comments suggesting that perhaps the workload ought to be distributed more fairly. My wife put her hand on my leg, and I was waiting to feel a hard squeeze telling me to 'SHUT UP.' It never came, so I took that as a vote of confidence . . . and pushed things a bit beyond everyone's comfort when I suggested we do pizza next year. No fuss, no muss.

That was a sacrilege.

“No way.”

"It's tradition."

"It's got to be duck. We always had duck for Christmas—even during the war we had duck. Nothing the rest of the year, but duck at Christmas."

And so forth until we come around to a long forgotten truth. Christmas Eve had always been celebrated with fondue until I came along with my lactose intolerance and changed the game plan. Ever after it had been goose or duck with duck being the clear preference. So, all those years ago I had mucked it up. Later, on reflection, it occurs to me that I'd taken the blame unnecessarily. You see, the kids were all living at home when there were two separate celebrations—one on Christmas Eve with fondue and one on Christmas Day with duck. After the nest emptied, it was a struggle to get everyone to show up twice during the holidays, so Grandma legislated that Christmas Eve was the compromise. Duck it would be. Fondue was out. Almost in her 10th decade, when the stakes are high (in her judgment), she continues to lay down the law in her own uniquely effective way.

Now my wife feels obligated (she tends to overestimate her obligations) to prepare Christmas dinner since Grandma is no longer able to. I tell her that this comes from being the oldest. As the youngest in my family, I've shared with her the cunning of younger siblings when it comes to shirking. But the oldest don't always listen to the youngest when they should.

Well, maybe tradition can be tweaked again . . . just a bit. That might be OK if we can persuade everybody to go back to the older tradition of having fondue. The only difficulty is that Christmas Eve had been fondue and Christmas Day had been the feast of fowl and that would put us right back where we started. Another complication: Sister-in-Law and her gentrified partner were sponsors of a new custom. Years ago, they started their own mini-tradition by inviting Grandma to their house on Christmas Day. Nobody else, just Grandma. We felt slighted, but no one raised any objections. It would be a tropical February day in northern Nunavut when Grandma's invitation would be extended to the rest of the

family. And even if it were, I'm pretty sure it would be roundly rejected.
Tradition can be a hard thing to break with. And once broken, restoring it can be all but impossible.

Now, opening presents can also be a tricky part of the Christmas Eve ritual. There are self-selected gifts and these go over predictably well. But some of the gift guesses are way off, leaving the recipient nonplussed but obliged to show gratitude. My wife, fresh from hearing of the napkin affair at my sister's back during American Thanksgiving, had internalized the lesson: don't correct or otherwise critique the bad behaviour or stupidity of another's offspring. Thus prepared, she successfully deflected a near explosion when Nephew reproached her for giving him a small 3D popup Christmas card depicting a manger scene. That evening with fists in mouths we were all educated in fundamental Baptist theology, including Catholic Grandma. You see, nativity scenes are idolatrous and only Catholics partake of this wickedness. In my head, I answer very sarcastically that I thought Christianity had moved on past its primitive sectarianism. A good thing, because it's possible that my views have become outdated, in which case I would be factually wrong and Christmas would have ended very badly and for no really good reason. Moreover, giving in to such temptation would not have endeared me to my wife who'd already bitten her tongue to the point of drawing blood. Just a drop.

* * *

Next day, word from Grandma reports that Brother-in-Law is of the opinion—and his can be the decisive one—that his older sister (my wife) has been doing more than her fair share and that this needs to change. HURRAY! But calm down. It's unfair to hold someone to extravagant promises made during the exuberance of the Season.

However, the duck stays. Read this as a resounding refusal by all of the blood relatives to substitute pizza or any ethnic food for good old duck. I feel duly put in my place. Tradition *is* tradition because it resists the currents of change, however unreasonable it may appear to outsiders.

But assessing the situation realistically, two emendations to intergenerational family customs in a lifetime may just be too radical to preserve the health and well-being of all parties at the table. Evolution is a S-L-O-W process.

On hearing the news, I smile at my wife with tongue in cheek. I know getting my wife to ‘let go’ will be almost as difficult as preparing the full Christmas Eve dinner sans duck.

The Friar, the Engineer and the Speculator (December 2025)

In the 19th century, the blurring of empire and statehood in present-day New Mexico was facilitated by war and innovation, history's prime movers. In this tale, which also anticipates the past's future, contemporaneity is only slightly inconvenienced in order to move the plot along. However, in the main, our cast operates in close spatial proximity, roughly within the boundaries of the present American state of New Mexico. Jumping about in time is unquestionably more unnerving than similar movements in space, so the reader's patience is respectfully requested. What follows is a preliminary sketch of our three characters and their place in our tale, which owing to publication deadlines is limited in brevity and depth.

The tech-savvy Franciscan, Brother Dreyfus, uses an iPad to record speech from the Chiricahua and Navajo. He then translates directly into his native French and occasional Spanish, bypassing Latin which he never learned. Nevertheless, he is uncomfortably familiar with the concept of *terra nullius* all too well. Brother Dreyfus keeps his translations secret, for if the Church finds out about them, he will be put on the first ship back to Spain or worse. His work would be a sacrilege as it contradicts the spirit of the Papal Bulls that legitimate the Spanish Crown's empire building in the Americas. Ultimately, he is found out, through no little help from one of Geronimo's spies it's been said, and shipped back to Spain, where one door closing leads to another door opening.

Our Franciscan meets Macintosh, a Scottish engineer from Edinburgh, who introduces him to the latest steam technologies and is, in turn, fascinated by the friar's iPad and its technical and commercial potential. Macintosh is traveling throughout the territory to study the steam technology in use and suggest improvements in its deployment, particularly in silver mining. His mission is to assess

the market for British mining equipment, notably the stamp mill and the steam monkey. The stamp mill pulverizes ore in order to retrieve minerals, foremost among them silver, while the steam monkey comprising a wood-burning steam boiler, powerful winches and thick metal cables loaded on wooden skids (more like logs shaped into enormous Bunyanesk skis) can haul heavy loads over difficult terrain or along tramway lines in the deep mines. Brother Dreyfus regards the steam donkey with a mixture of fear and humour but settles on a third emotion, joy. Joy, because he can envision the future where Indians (once for a short while, the name for the indigenous people of Turtle Island) need no longer be forcibly conscripted alongside inmates from nearby prisons and jails to do the back-breaking and dangerous lifting and moving.

Macintosh introduces the good friar to Knebel who tells him about George Hearst and his dream of a publication empire. Apparently the idea came to George when he saw how important the mining camp newspapers had become—miners didn't have to wait for weeks for the Eastern press to reach them and their local papers provide much better coverage of news that is relevant. As a prospector and later a speculator, Knebel, who picks up languages very quickly, travels widely along the Red and Canadian rivers in eastern New Mexico territory and the Rio Grande and Pecos rivers from south to north and north to south. Because many of his speculative ventures never pan out, he is often on the move. He never meets Geronimo but hears many stories not all of which are flattering as it seems that Geronimo is not wildly popular among his tribal members. His intransigence in negotiating with the pale faces leads to what many think is needless slaughter of their young braves and innocents.

In our next installment, interactions among the principals will proceed on the basis of the backstory provided herein.

"Tell me you came back for a reason."

No response.

The only sound comes from the clock ticking on the wall above the coat hooks, where his leather jacket hangs alongside his walking stick. His cowboy hat with the Navajo headband sits on the wooden bench by the back door.

"Thought I hung that up."

Pause.

"So?"

His eyes pass across the kitchen. The kitchen cupboard is closed, and he's certain he'd left it open when he took out the Brim.

He starts to take a sip of coffee, but it's gone cold.

"You weren't exactly welcome the last time you popped in for a visit, and I thought I made myself clear."

Without thinking, he reaches out for the coffee cup again, but this time, he pulls his hand away quickly.

"Ow! Did you do that?"

There's no other sound than the clock facing him. The animals have all been fed and put to bed. This is his time, and all he wants is to be left alone. Nobody needing anything from him and no jobs needing tending to . . . leastwise, not in the middle of the night.

Out of habit, he takes another sip of coffee but now it’s just the way he likes it.

"You know I had to do it. You do know that now, don't you?"

Pause.

"Damn, I hate it when you're like this. Say something!"

Longer pause.

Shaking his head, he looks down at the coffee cup. Beside it is a slice of apple pie on an enamel dessert plate, the one with the red rose in the center.

"Is this a peace offering or something?"

No answer.

"Listen, I'm sorry it had to be this way. The doctors said there was no other way. They even said you might get better."

Extended pause.

From outside he hears the soft lowing of his milk cows.

"Good night, Sadie."

The Bolillo (December 2025)

“I can't forgive myself for what I did.”

The short obscure message had been baked into a bolillo by A. Cruz, a volunteer with a Caritas mission serving border communities in Nuevo Mexico.

Cruz hand-delivered the bolillo to Frankie, a defrocked Franciscan living in a wild cave near Carlsbad.

Months earlier, Cruz had befriended a Peace Corps worker and fallen in love. During their liaison, he had carelessly shared sensitive information about Mexico's new border with America.

Within days of their breakup, as Cruz later learned, recons from the paramilitary group, Demonios Americanos, appeared in Frank’s neighbourhood.

Under contract with the U.S. military, they were equipped with prototypes of advanced weaponry that can destroy mountains. However, in previous tests, many of the weapons had misfired when deployed in the field. This was to be a crucial test.

Recon had been unable to assemble precise target coordinates owing to the unclimbable topography, but it was good enough. The new weapon sliced through the mountain rock causing massive landslides as entire cliff walls sheared off and triggered rock avalanches that swept everything in their path to the bottom of the canyon. Any habitable caves would have collapsed under the barrage of weaponry.

A Safety PSA (January 2026)

A young woman is talking on her cell with her husband while driving along a curvy mountainous two-lane road. The winds at this elevation are strong and the roads are icy. A young man is driving in the opposite direction, speaking with a friend on a hands-free phone.

A utility pole has fallen across the road and the wires have snapped and are lying on the ground. The man pumps his brakes and comes to a smooth stop about 20 feet from the pole. The woman brakes but skids off the road onto the shoulder. The vehicles are about 100 feet apart but the drivers are visible to one another. Outside the car, the winds are howling through the trees.

The man lowers his window and urgently motions to the woman with the palms of his hands facing her. She nods her but then reaches for her seatbelt. He shouts “NO” and shakes his head vigorously. She pauses.

Now that he has her attention, he points to the wires in the roadway and simulates being electrocuted. She nods again.

Next, he puts his left hand to his ear as if he’s holding a phone. She nods. Then holding up her wrist, she points to her watch.

He holds up his right index finger as he speaks into the receiver (little finger) of his left hand. She waits, takes a deep breath and puts the palm of her hand on her forehead and pushes her hair back.

He signals with all five fingers of this right hand. Then, he points towards her, gives an OK signal and shrugs his shoulders with the palms of his hands upturned.

She nods and motions the same question back to him.
He nods and leans back putting his head on the headrest.

Out of the corner of his eye, he sees the door of her car begin to open.

He honks repeatedly and screams “NO,” shaking his head as if willing her to stay put.

She opens the car door just enough to let a little fluffy white dog out to pee.

Again, he screams and honks but it's too late.

* * *

The utility workers arrive and assess the situation. After a couple of minutes, they confer. Then, they give the thumbs up.

“Lucky for ‘Precious’ these were telephone wires,” says one of the workers as he shakes his head.

Elevator Speak (March 2026)

Two strangers stand facing one another across a crowded elevator. Eyes meet.

The one listening to music tilts her head to the side and wrinkles her brow. The other, a head taller than everyone else, tilts his head to the opposite side and raises his eyebrows.

When the elevator stops at the 18th floor, a mother and two young boys get in.

Tall Guy's eyes go saucer-like. Earbuds mirrors the look and then smiles showing perfect teeth.

Just at that moment, the youngest boy glances up at Earbuds and mouths "Wow!"

He gets an elbow in the back.

Earbuds grants a benevolent smile.

Tall Guy winks.

The youngest fiddles with his windbreaker, humming along as he zips and unzips.

The older boy shoves him and stage whispers, "Told you not to do that."

The youngest pushes back. "What?"

"You know what?"

"Boys," the mother says.

Earbuds wrinkles her nose and raises an eyebrow. Tall Guy looks down and turns from head to head. He stops and points with his eyes at an old man with a walker. Earbuds half-nods and reaches for a Kleenex.

"Ach, God. I forgot my hearing aids. Stop at the next floor, please."

Earbuds presses 11. She holds her breath.

The elevator comes to a stop and the old man with the walker squeezes through and trundles out.

Tall Guy turns his face to the ceiling, sniffs and satisfied blinks twice to Earbuds. She inhales normally and returns a tentative smile.

The door closes, and with that, several deep breaths are taken but cut short.

"Bobby!"

"Wasn't me!"

"Boys, shh!"

Earbuds reaches for the Kleenex again. In sync, the tall guy scans his fellow travelers, this time without moving his head.

In the back of the elevator a well-dressed older woman with two large Louis Vuitton-monogrammed suitcases twitches her nose and coughs a couple of times. Next to her, a teenager puts his skateboard down and pulls his hoodie around to cover his face. A

young girl with a white Miniature Poodle cradled in her arms, her face a bright red, exhales explosively—her peppermint breath somewhat refreshing—and then covers her face with her scarf sucking in air with such force that the dog yips.

Earbuds and Tall Guy raise their eyebrows in unison.

Finally, the elevator reaches the ground floor and the passengers make hasty exits.

Earbuds and Tall Guy, having politely made way for the others, are the last to leave.

Now alone, they can let down their guard. But as they pass through the door, Earbuds masks her face with the Kleenex she's been clutching nearly the whole way, while Tall Guy sniffs suspiciously as he checks the air quality in the lobby.

As if on cue, they point at one another and exclaim, "YOU!"

Arnie wasn't going to be convinced until he saw the proof for himself.

Do other people exist apart from my thinking about them? He didn't think so. He could never verify their existence without them being there. Or, at least being part of his own experience. This caused him difficulties during childhood. He got into lots of fights. Usually, this was the outcome when he told the other kids that he'd leave and disappear them if they didn't do what he told them to do. Most of the time he came out the loser.

He was orphaned early. His parents' will designated some corporation to assume management of the trusteeship in the event of their passing. So, somewhere in the Caribbean, his new family looked after his material needs.

In college he was quite argumentative and refractory with both students and faculty. The philosophy department encouraged him to switch majors when he repeatedly refused to acknowledge the independent reality of his professors. He didn’t take the suggestion well. The department eventually had to bar him from all classes. The psychology department was more indulgent for the simple reason that he provided them with a unique research opportunity, but once word got out about the types of experiments they were performing, he had to be released and all contact with the department severed. He tried accounting but that was a predictable bust. So, he dropped out of college.

He had started his own experiments in junior high school. He'd taken some of more common hallucinogens like LSD, magic mushrooms and mescaline. He'd even tried the chemical derived from the venom of some rare amphibian found only in the Rocky

Mountains of the United States. All of them expanded his range of experience, but everything came back to HIM. Everything was relative to HIM. He never managed to escape HIMSELF and see the world through someone else's eyes.

With the assistance of a rare friend from his high school days, he engaged the services of a law firm that specialized in trust busting. This had nothing to do with traditional antitrust law and corporate monopolies. These were private trusts that managed the wealth of ultra-high-net-worth families like his. By the time he turned 30, he had wrested full control of the family trust from the Bahamian corporation.

Now, with no limit to how much he could spend, he set about organizing a competitive research program among the five largest pharmaceutical companies in the world and several off-the-books projects in Eastern Europe, Russia, Israel and China. Over time, he could boast of having multiple trials being staged around the world. Subjects were recruited to participate in the testing of a variety of potential break-out hallucinogens, but they were sufficiently well paid so most didn't object to the secrecy. Those that did were culled.

The single most important objective of the billions of dollars he poured into pharmacological and pharmaceutical research was to isolate a chemical that could produce the effect of experiencing the world exactly the way another person experiences it. Since there was no guarantee that such a chemical could be discovered and subsequently manufactured, the program was open-ended. It could take years or decades or it could go on forever.

———

He was in his eighties when the first promising drug candidate emerged. So eager was he to live to see the results of his efforts,

he insisted on a trial for himself despite countless warnings that his declining health put him at grave risk.

One entire wing of a private hospital (one of his) was dedicated to the experiment and top specialists from around the world were requisitioned. That would be the correct term for his offers were very persuasive and he didn't brook resistance.

The doctors set him up to receive the test drug intravenously so they could calibrate the release of the chemical as they monitored his physiological responses. Once the dosage was optimally calibrated, the next stage would be to transfer his consciousness to the body of another person. A long list of legal and medical prohibitions had prevented this experiment from ever having been performed before, so far as anyone knew. Unsurprisingly, as this was the most dangerous stage of the experiment, there were no volunteers. Recruiting had to pursue a different approach. More than a hundred homeless individuals were interviewed over a period of two weeks. It took that many and that long to find just one who was found to be physically fit and psychologically stable enough to undergo the procedure.

On the day of the operation, the brains of the two patients were connected to permit the sharing of consciousness. Once the transfer had taken place, the homeless man was to be asked a number of biographical questions followed by questions concerning his attendant perceptions, thoughts and emotions.

But all didn't go as planned. The procedure was accompanied by off the chart readings of the patients' vitals, and so it was abruptly terminated. The homeless man didn't respond to any of the preset questions. Instead, he droned on, mumbling bitterly about a wasted life.

From the adjacent operating table, the other patient sat upright on hearing a familiar voice. Pushing the blue sheets off, he looked down at his body. What he saw nearly choked him as he tried to force out a scream. These were not HIS skeletal arms and legs, draped as they were with saggy, translucent skin. Slowly taking in the whole of the operating theatre, with a tired and gravelly voice, he cried out, "Who IS that?," nodding in the direction of the other patient. “And who are YOU people and what have you done to ME?"

I get thrown in with no introductions. It's an assembly plant for automobile radiators. First thing on the factory floor, I pop in the earplugs. You could go deaf in a day without them. Even so, I feel the hammering of the stamping machines that surround the station where I've been assigned. I try to locate the supervisor, but every time I see the little bald guy—the one they call Li'l Boss—perambulating about, he disappears off in a different direction before I can find out what I'm supposed to be doing.

I manage to get the foreman's attention instead—the guy who's giving the directions.

"Pick up the scrap aluminum, the cardboard and the strapping."

"Where's it go?"

He points to the huge door near the loading dock.

Shoulder shrug.

"Scrap metal over to the blue steel bin out back and cardboard in the green one."

"That's it?"

"Yep. Make sure you keep the walkways free and make sure you clean up any spills pronto."

All around me, the people are heads down in synchronized motion with the machines. Now and then, a begoggled head pops up and someone steals a look at the large red numbers on the digital clock high up on the plant wall. Three o'clock is the magical hour for this

shift. There isn’t much talking. Nothing you can make out unless you’re in someone’s face. People sign with one another and do a lot of pointing. The mechanics have the larger vocabulary, but only they understood one another.

No one is idle. I get the hint when standing around looking for something to do, an old guy, looking to be in his late 60s, points to me and then to the broom nearby. I'd been in places like this before so I knew that it’s all important to stay busy if you want to come back the next day.

These aren’t the kind of jobs you want to talk about once you punch out. I mean, who's going to brag about temping in a factory? What do you say, when someone asks, "So, where do you work?" You have to be careful, because you know the next question is "And what do you do there?"

But, it's a job. And there aren't many good ones around. Lots of folks will tell you otherwise, but ask them if they’ve looked recently. And it's an honest living, but over the years you get pretty bummed out working for an honest living. Polite folks look away when you mention silly words like integrity. Others laugh or shake their heads.

The most difficult conversations come in the break rooms. People are curious. They want to know what brought you there. You want to talk about your writing, but you know it’s dangerous. You tell them that you write fictional stories some of which are drawn from your own experience in the world of work, and you mention high tech, university, government, manufacturing, retail, but no banks. You stress FICTION. Back in your early days when you were still stupid, you once said, “I’m a writer and I’m doing research for a book.” Word got around and the assignment ended at 3:00 p.m.

At the word ‘fiction,’ eyes begin to roll. People clear their throats. Interest disappears. Until a jokester, and every shift has at least one, decides to address the entire group, "Hey everybody. We got ourselves a writer here." That'll be the point when you finish swallowing what's left of your pride. But you can't let it show. "It ain't no big thing," you might say, or something like that, which is true enough and it doesn't make you out to be a trumped-up fool and most importantly you come across as too naïve to be a corporate spy or investigate reporter.

Sometimes, I do get awfully tempted to work an angle to land a cushy, respectable sales or management job. I do have THE college degree, and my sister-in-law IS a rich bitch whose family owns several factories and warehouses. It's within reach, and my former girlfriend, who agreed with too much enthusiasm that my sister-in-law is a bitch, kept telling me “Just Do It.”

I don't know. Cause once in a while, a guy like Edsel, the ‘go to’ mechanic from my last gig, a six-monther, comes up to you and asks, "So, you write about shitholes like this, huh?"

And you answer, "Yeah, I try to."

“Well, I’ll tell you what. I can't write for a damn, but I can tell you stories. The ones that don’t never get told."

That night, I couldn’t sleep. It felt like a new job offer had just fallen in my lap. Writing the stories of people who have the stories to tell. But, stories that too few care to read let alone buy. I’ll never be a Studs Terkel, but . . . wouldn't it solve MY biggest problems?

The shift’s coming to an end. The reinforcements—the afternoon shift—arrive, and for the next ten minutes, the A shift catches the B shift up. They’re basically shouting at each other from two feet

away, because the machines, they never stop. Mostly the guys (we're unisex here) are chatting about whatever they fancy, weather, sports, kids. It's a rare occasion during the eight-hour grind.

Once the whistle sounds, it takes less than a minute for us, the A shift, to be gone. The door doesn't hit anyone on the backside.

B shift's magical hour is 11:00 p.m. One or two have already taken in the red numbers on the digital clock.

Reviewing *Sparks* (July 2025)

Sparks: China's Underground Historians and Their Battle for the Future was published in 2023, a decade plus into Xi Jinping's forever leadership. The author is Ian Johnson who is currently a Senior Fellow at the Council on Foreign Relations, publisher of the international relations journal *Foreign Affairs*. He is a longtime correspondent who has spent nearly two decades reporting in China for the *Baltimore Sun*, the W*all Street Journal* and the *New York Times*. In 2001, while reporting for the WSJ, he won the Pulitzer Prize for reporting on China's persecution of the Falun Gong.

The book title, *Sparks,* is a link to China's past underground historians and the short-lived journal, *Spark*. Like that long defunct journal, the title is intended to evoke the image of sudden and unpredictable moment when "a single spark can start a prairie fire," illuminating a dark world. Referring to the longstanding effort to keep history intact in the face of official efforts to rewrite the past to align with contemporary Communist Party ideology, he writes,

> If the history of this movement has taught us anything, it is that it has grown with time, despite setbacks. We can look at individual battles and see defeat. But we can also see an endless cycle of creation, of new sparks that leap off the flint of history every time it is struck.

For this reviewer, the great value of Johnson's book is the introduction to a much larger base of Chinese dissent. Up until five years ago, I had not read much in the way of Chinese dissidents. That contrasts sharply with my readings of Soviet and East Bloc dissident authors. In 2021, I set out to find China's Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn. The Liao Yiwu was by some called just that, so I read

several of his works that had been translated into English.(1) It seems that the literature of political dissent was promoted more vigorously when it came out of Europe. Perhaps it had something to do with the Cold War between the U.S. and the U.S.S.R., and maybe there was a cultural bias in favour of things European. Regardless, Johnson's book is a welcome addition as more writings—including science fiction, which often carries subtle (and sometimes not so subtle) political commentary—from China are becoming available to Anglophones.

While to outsiders, China might appear to be a monolithic society of faceless, brainwashed simpletons, Johnson informs us that there are many who refuse to take the political system as incorrigibly fixed by faraway and mysterious forces. Life is often difficult enough without taking on a virtually omnipotent adversary, especially with the temptations of easy living. There are, of course, those whose mercenary instincts compel them to 'mind' others or brutally torture and kill them on behalf of the Party. And then there are those who from an overabundance of zealousness and/or self-righteous are willing to 'mind' or torture without charging a fee. Neither the underground historians nor Johnson hide these actors as is made plain in the book. However, there are those who, though rightfully fearful of the consequences, are willing to challenge the Party—the omnipotent adversary of any who cut through the Party's lies of disremembering. Just why they do so is an important part of the stories that Johnson tells.

For Johnson, history is the battleground where the underground historians challenge the dogma of Party history. According to Johnson, there have been different versions of Party history since the founding of the People's Republic of China. The first he identifies with Mao Zedong, the second with Deng Xiaoping and the third with Xi Jinping. To understand Party history is to better understand official China. Mao's China is for outsiders the China of

failed economic and social policies, most notably land reform, the Great Leap Forward and the Cultural Revolution. Deng's China is regarded as a turn away from China's fixation on a rapid socialist transformation of society and the economy and towards a more open, productive and free enterprise economy. Xi's China is a synthesis, an assertion of the Chinese 'way,' state capitalism under the control of a single party, the Communist Party.

Where Johnson takes issue with modern China is with the one-party state, and in particular an authoritarian (interestingly, he rarely uses the word totalitarian) party-state that intends to create a conformist society aligned with the principles and values of the Party. For that to happen, the party-state needs to control history, rewriting disasters of the past and embellishing achievements. Writing of Xi's China, Johnson states that

> Since taking power in 2012, Xi Jinping has made control of history a top domestic priority. He has closed scores of unauthorized journals and museums and jailed those who oppose his version of the truth. These acts of disremembering warp the country's collective memory and have succeeded in convincing most Chinese people that even if the party is flawed, it is doing a good job and its opponents are at best unrealistic, and at worst traitors.

Johnson explains Jinping's strategy in the context of what Xi considers to be the failure of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union to control the minds and memories of the people, which ultimately led to the collapse of the U.S.S.R. in 1991. Johnson writes,

> The Soviet Union had collapsed because its leaders had allowed alternative versions of history to take root. Later versions of this story, some of them written in books and others told in ominous videos, put the fault much earlier.

> Instead of Gorbachev being to blame, it was Khrushchev and his de-Stalinization campaign of the 1950s that allowed the rot to set in. In this regard, Xi and Mao were similar. Mao, too, perceived the de-Stalinization of the 1950s as a debacle, a dangerous admission of error that should not have been allowed. For China, the last great communist power standing, this mistake would not be repeated.

The underground historians documented in Johnson's book are threats and thus enemies of Xi and the Party, which explains why for Xi it is so important not to yield to those who would subvert the Party's authority over China's history, especially history since the inception of the Party in the 1920s. The punishments for noncompliance are severe—loss of livelihood and even life itself. It is against the backdrop of the battle of the underground historians and the Party that Johnson assembles his cast of characters who are far too many to be mentioned in this brief review. A few examples are briefly mentioned below.

There is Lin Zhao an improbable blend of Christian and communist who refused to recant during the Anti-Rightist Campaign of the late 1950s. She was killed. Then, there is Hu Jie, a filmmaker and artist, whose films resurrect histories of the Anti-Rightist Campaign, the Great Famine and the Cultural Revolution and whose drawings and woodblocks reflect a deep influence from Holocaust remembrances. Next is Fang Lizhi, the author of the famous essay, 'The Chinese Amnesia,'(2) in which he declares that "about once each decade, the true face of history is thoroughly erased from the memory of Chinese society. This is the objective of the Chinese Communist policy of 'Forgetting History.'"

And there is Huang Zerong, living in internal exile and watched over by Party minders, who responds to Johnson's question whether the

Communist Party's Anti-Rightist campaign of 70 years earlier still matters, as follows,

> Without the Anti-Rightist Campaign there would have been no Great Leap Forward; without the Great Leap Forward, people would not have starved to death. If people hadn't starved to death, there would not have been the Cultural Revolution. Without the Cultural Revolution, there would not have been Tiananmen.

In other words, yes, accurate history matters because it can, if allowed, contribute to what will happen in the future. Catastrophic historical events cannot be averted if there is no historical reference to their having happened before.

Then, there is Tan Hecheng, who Johnson maintains is solely responsible for the fact that the world knows the truth about Dao County during the Cultural Revolution. Hecheng spent 40 years researching and writing about it and first published his findings in 2011. Johnson presents this graphic summary of Hecheng's research.

> For several weeks in August 1967, more than nine thousand people were murdered in this region. Its epicenter was Dao County, which the Xiao River bisects on its way north toward the Xiang and then the Yangtze. About half the victims were killed in this county of 400,000 people, some clubbed to death and thrown into limestone pits, others tossed into sweet potato cellars to suffocate. Many were tied together in bundles around a charge of quarry explosives. These victims were called "homemade airplanes" because their body parts flew over the fields. But most victims were simply bludgeoned to death with agricultural tools—hoes, carrying poles, and rakes—and then tossed into the waterways that flow into the Xiao.

Prior to reading Liao Yiwu, I had heard about the long-suffering Christians in China. One had to admire their bravery. Though not necessarily regarded as political, they were of course political insofar as they resisted the Party's control of religion. Sometimes Christian missionaries are dismissed as being little more than the softer side of Western imperialism and that charge may be true in a general sense and in the particulars of some organizations and people. Here, Liao's book, *God Is Red*, can be offered in evidence of these peoples' courage. It is noteworthy that Liao, while sympathetic to the Chinese Christians he interviewed, openly declares himself to be a nonbeliever.

Earlier in this review, the question why these underground historians, as unofficial historians have often done in China's past, would dare engage in "asymmetrical battle" against "an overwhelmingly strong state."

> They write diaries and articles that attract large audiences. They are shut down. But they return, again and again, just as they and their forebears have for seventy-five years.

There is no easy answer to the question, "Why?" As curator of the work of so many underground historians in China, Johnson can best answer by sharing their voices.

Johnson does offer one intriguing explanation that may lie in the back of the minds of this never-ending stream of dissidents. It is this,

> Stopping these people from working requires an inordinate commitment of resources. It is not the same as an operation to close down a magazine. It means deploying scores of agents 24/7 for each person who has to be

> stopped. . . . But China has thousands of people contributing to this movement. It can't be done to all of them all the time.
>
> This battle is already exacting a steep toll on the state. Most estimates are that the money spent on China's domestic intelligence services rivals the national defense budget, with each accounting for 10 percent of government expenditures.

Johnson concludes this argument by observing a resemblance between the "unstoppable juggernaut" of the Chinese state and the once-thought indomitable Stasi security apparatus of East Germany.

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Endnotes

(1) Johnson mentions Liao Yiwu, an important contemporary oral historian and artist, but only in passing. Liao has been referred to as China's Alexander Solzhenitsyn on account of his four years as a political prisoner, his detailed memoirs of the horrors of Chinese prisons, the confiscation of all of his notes (for *For a Song*) not once but twice, and the prohibition against his publishing in China. The events of June 4, 1989 at Tiananmen Square marked a decisive turn for the worse for Liao. He published the poem 'Massacre' and that earned him a prison sentence. After years of harassment by the secret police, he literally walked out of China. He made for Hanoi and caught a plane to Berlin where he was welcomed. He still lectures across Germany. Some of his important works include: *For a Song and One Hundred Songs: a Poet's Journey Through a Chinese Prison; God is Red: The*

Secret Story of How Christianity Survived and Flourished in Communist China; The Corpse Walker: Real Life Stories: China From the Bottom Up; and Bullets and Opium: *Real-Life Stories of China After the Tiananmen Square Massacre.* Johnson wrote the following in his Introduction to the English version of *Bullets and Opium*, explaining why this book is so important.

> It is not a definitive history of Tiananmen but something more compelling: intimate interviews with people who fought for the revolution, were jailed, and were then released to a country that had suddenly turned away from politics and embraced the deadening pleasures of consumer society and the cheap thrills of nationalism.

(2) "The Chinese Amnesia." *New York Review of Books*, September 27, 1990. Translated by Perry. Link. https://www.nybooks.com/articles/1990/09/27/the-chinese-amnesia.

Reviewing *Red Scare: Memories of the American Inquisition* (August 2025)

This collection of oral histories of the Second American Red Scare(1) is now 30 years old, but it is an important part of American history that must be remembered. Accordingly, Griffin Fariello includes the following epigraph authored by the Czech dissident, Milan Kundera: “The struggle of man against power is the struggle of memory against forgetting.”

In the Preface, Fariello calls his book a book of memories . . . memories of more than 60 individuals who lived during the Red Scare, a period he marks as beginning in 1945 and ending roughly in 1965. He describes his book as

> an attempt to rescue a chapter of history from our habitual “forgettery,” a mosaic of voices from both sides of the Great Fear. Here are ordinary men and women—Communists, progressives, and New Dealers alike—as they recall their lives under the Inquisition. Here also are the hounds that hunted them—the Attorney General, the union boss, the FBI agent, the security officer, and the professional informer.

By way of introduction, he continues,

> From the hunted who cooperated, there are regrets and confusion, and earnest explanations. After more than forty years, they still struggle to be understood. From those who resisted, there is pride in having behaved well in difficult times. There is anger and sorrow aplenty for the friendships betrayed, the lives and careers cut short, and the resulting years of struggle. Laughter comes into play too, as dark as it may be, for every Inquisition is at its core an enormous absurdity, and the relief of humor is as

> evident today as it was then.(2) Ultimately, however, this is a story of America at midcentury when, at the pinnacle of national strength, we turned in fear to strike down our own.

Fariello takes care to explain that McCarthyism, which is what most of us think of when we think of the Communist Scare post-World War II, is only part of a much larger phenomenon of a government seeking to change the trajectory of the nation's purpose and control any incipient dissent. With the other great powers severely politically and economically exhausted by the world war, America, an emerging great power whose homeland was relatively untouched by the destruction of war, was destined to lead the world.

According to Fariello, Britain's cession of its sphere of interest in Greece to the U.S. marked a decisive point in international relations. With the war over, and the alliance with the U.S.S.R. ended, America took its role in Greece quite seriously, essentially framing the Cold War Truman Doctrine from its newfound foreign policy objective of containing the spread of Soviet Communism. The Red Scare is the domestic policy tailored to correspond with America's new world mission.

Truman articulated the business case for the Truman Doctrine at Baylor University in an address on March 6, 1947. In the speech he referred to three freedoms: "Freedom of worship—freedom of speech—freedom of enterprise." For any who might be tempted to think of Communism as a viable political option, Truman observed that "It must be true that the first two of these freedoms are related to the third," for "peace, freedom, and world trade are indivisible." But he knew that would not sell his foreign policy to the American public, as it "made the whole thing sound like an investment prospectus." He, therefore, concluded that the new policy had to be marketed differently, emphasizing the theme of a global contest

between Democracy and Communism, the free world and totalitarianism.

To facilitate the conditioning of the American mind to the new world order and America's new role therein, Fariello writes,

> President Truman brought his anti-Communist war home to America. On March 25, 1947, he put his signature to Executive Order 9835 and launched the Federal Employees Loyalty Program, the most sweeping loyalty inquiry in the nation's history. E.O. 9835 authorized investigations into the beliefs and associations of all federal employees. This first such peacetime program was so vaguely worded that in time every aspect of an employee's personal life would be opened to federal scrutiny. Moreover, the accused would not have the right to confront the accuser or, in almost every case, even be privy to the accusation.

In this view, Truman was the initiator of the Second Red Scare. McCarthy was not on the scene, and in fact, his entire *raison d'être* had not yet been created. As Fariello writes, "While McCarthy made the notion of security risks in the federal bureaucracy a national obsession from 1950 to 1954, the ground in which he flourished had been well prepared before his arrival."

According to Fariello, Truman set the stage. "The public, rather than question the loyalty program, naturally assumed the existence of the disloyal and the subversive—for why else would there be a program to uncover them?" Truman's belief in the urgency combating subversive dangers at home motivated Congress, in the person of McCarthy to expand the purges and investigations. Eisenhower followed up with his version of citizen loyalty, arguing that Truman had been too lax in ignoring the security threat from loyal employees.

> Eisenhower's Executive Order 10450 mandated immediate suspension without pay for "any behavior, activities, or associations which tend to show that the individual is not reliable or trustworthy." No provisions for hearings were made, leaving it up to the discretion of the agency or department head. . . . Now employees would be summarily sacked for pleading the Fifth Amendment [right against self incrimination] before a congressional committee.

The famous loyalty question was this: Are you now or have you ever been a member of the Communist Party? If one answered 'Yes', then names of associates were expected and failure to provide them would be regarded as contempt of Congress, a jailable offense. A 'No' answer would usually not be believed, and further interrogations and investigations could be expected. Many of the voices in this collected oral history corroborate this, describing the extremes of FBI harassment and intimidation practices.(3)

So, far the Red Scare has been mostly framed in terms of its impact on First Amendment free speech activities. Fariello and several of the oral histories testify to an even more insidious effect. First, the Red Scare can be considered a repudiation of FDR's New Deal and government's new activist role in promoting social justice. Second, the Red Scare can be looked as a cover for denying civil rights to Blacks, especially in the Southern states. New Dealers and civil rights activists could be cast as Communists and that was often enough to instigate surveillance, interrogations, investigations and even violence (e.g., the Southern predilection for cross-burning, church-burning and lynching.)

In the following, a few oral histories will be referenced and quoted in part in order to give a flavour of the work.

M. Wesley Swearingen was a special agent of the FBI from 1951 to 1977. He was involved in 'political' work, such as surveillance, illegal break-ins, and maintenance of the Security Index. (The Index was a list of Americans who were to put in concentration camps during a national emergency.) Referring to his work as a case agent when he was not doing bag jobs (covert and often illegal), he relates that

> I'm reading their speeches and what they write and listening to what they say, and I'm thinking, "Gee, this isn't all that bad. They want equal rights in the union for minorities and blacks and equal pay for women. What the hell is wrong with this?" And I couldn't find that anybody was breaking any laws. Maybe someone would get a parking ticket, but that happens to anybody. . . . As far as I could see, they just wanted to have things a little bit better and that's all.

And then recalling the Cuban Missile Crisis, he states that

> [W]e were within a hairbreadth of actually activating a roundup [using the Security Index). We knew darn well that when the first missile comes flying from Cuba, we're going to be out there throwing people in a camp. . . . I don't know where in Chicago we were going to throw them. One time, I figured out the only place we could put so many people would be in Soldier Field.

And he concludes with the following overall assessment of the national security value of his work in the FBI during which he only made one arrest,

> It strikes me now, and it struck me then after a few years, that it was a waste of time and a waste of taxpayers' money. But it contributed to my total years of retirement

> and pension, so you look back and it's not all that bad, because I have a real nice retirement. But that's about the only benefit I can see out of it.

Arthur Miller was one of America's most famous playwrights. He was cited for contempt of Congress for refusing to name names, but his conviction was overturned and he never had to serve prison time. Though best known for *Death of a Salesman,* the play, *The Crucible,* ostensibly about the Salem witch trials of 1692 is a parable for America during the Red Scare. His political analysis of the Red Scare is briefly summed up in this quote,

> I think the roots of all this lie in that the Right had been out of power since 1934, and the prospects were bleak that they'd ever get back into power on the presidential level. They were defeated time and again, and this was a terrific way of reversing the whole liberal trend in the United States, which they succeeded in doing. They managed to create this atmosphere, which was basically a ploy by the right wing of the Republican Party from the outset, and also some of the Democrats, to turn the country to the right. They managed to turn back everything that had happened since Roosevelt started the New Deal. It was basically a domestic political struggle, which they won for a long time.

Claire Hartford was the Midwest regional director of the American Communications Association, a union that was affiliated with the Congress of Industrial Organizations (CIO). She describes herself and her husband as trade unionists who happened to be members of the Communist Party. She cites the 1939 Nonaggression Pact between Russia and Germany, which was promptly followed by their joint invasion and partitioning of Poland, as her first disillusionment with Communism. She recalls that it was particularly

bitter for her as a Jew, but they did not leave the Party. And for that they paid as she tells in her own words,

> I think if we didn't have the children, we would've been less fearful. If you starve it's one thing, but if you have kids, you constantly feel that responsibility. But it didn't stop us from doing what we believed in. We lost jobs, we were hounded from pillar to post. We watched friends of ours in the most awful situations—a lot of them went to jail. I think we survived pretty well emotionally. But we felt this terrible rage at what was happening, that we couldn't stop it, that it was going to be a long time before people woke up. It was sickening, it destroyed you in so many ways. But you had to live. You picked yourself up and went looking for jobs again.

She recalls having used their home to allow doctors from the community medical clinic where her husband worked, a Communist health organization according to the California State Un-American Committee, to stay to avoid being served with a subpoena. (It was legal to dodge a subpoena, but once served with a subpoena one was obligated to appear before the committee.)

Her concluding assessment of their experience during the Red Scare seems eerily prescient. (Remember that this book was published 30 years ago.)

> I know that my trust in the government vanished. I always feel that it can happen again, and that we're never very far from it. I don't think [sighs] that our elected officials really believe in the democracy that we're supposed to be. I feel that corruption has taken over, that morals and principles can be abandoned. A demagogue like McCarthy could come into power again; we're not immune to a Hitler. It's being proved every day. Violence is rising; hatreds and ethnic divisiveness are escalating.

There are many more oral histories that could have been selected for this review, but hopefully, those presented in this review will spark the reader's interest in having a look through the larger collection. For those who have enjoyed Studs Terkel's oral histories of America, *Red Scare* will be a familiar and welcome read.(4)

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Endnotes

(1) The First American Red Scare occurred near the end of World War I (which the U.S. joined late) and after the Bolshevik Revolution. The Espionage and Sedition Acts of 1917 and 1918 effectively stifled anti-war dissent, landing Eugene Debs, the Socialist Party's presidential candidate for the 1920 election, in jail where he nevertheless got more than 900,000 votes. In 1920, the U.S. population was only 106 million compared to today's 347 million. According to Fariello,

> The centerpiece of the post-World War One Red Scare, the Palmer Raids were a nationwide roundup of nearly ten thousand citizens and immigrants on the night of January 2, 1920. Sponsored by Attorney General A. Mitchell Palmer and orchestrated by his young subaltern J. Edgar Hoover, the raids were noted for their conspicuous brutality and a virtual absence of due process. In the ensuing backlash, Palmer and Hoover partly justified their actions against the aliens in purely racist terms, saying that "from their lopsided faces, sloping brows, and misshapen features may be recognized the unmistakable criminal type."

(2) At the beginning of the chapter, ‘Hounds,’ Fariello introduces “the network of professional informers, security officers, law enforcement agencies, anti-Communist pressure groups, and newsmen around the country.” The following anecdote gives some idea of the absurdly hysteria-driven surveillance and enforcement efforts.

> By 1956, with the Communist Party down to less than five thousand members, one out of every three members was an FBI informant. So riddled was the CP that informers named other informers, and many a meeting was held where the majority worked for the government.

(3) Fariello writes that J. Edgar Hoover’s FBI was “the most relentless force in the war against the Left. Hoover led the Bureau of Investigation, later named the Federal Bureau of Investigation, for 48 years from 1924 to his death in 1972. Fariello reports that

> Agents burgled, tapped, and bugged, suborned perjury, intimidated and blackmailed. During this period, the Bureau stockpiled more than 25 million files on American citizens. From 1941 to 1975 virtually every civil rights group, left-of-center labor union, and left-wing political organization (approximately 13,500 in total) was monitored by the FBI.

Martin Luther King, Jr., recipient of the Nobel Peace in 1964 and leader of America’s civil rights movement in the ‘50s and ‘60s up until his assassination in 1968, was one of Hoover’s long-term targets.

(4) For a comparative oral history of dissent from the People’s Republic of China, see Ian Johnson’s *Sparks: China's Underground Historians and Their*

Battle for the Future, published in 2023. Johnson's book introduces a much larger base of Chinese dissent than I have seen before in English translations. One noteworthy dissenter who receives only passing mention is Liao Yiwu, whose poem, 'Massacre', about the Tiananmen Square protest and ensuing violent suppression earned him a four-year sentence in China's prison gulag system. Liao documents his prison experience in his book, *For a Song and One Hundred Songs: a Poet's Journey Through a Chinese Prison*—a book that he had to start from scratch three times owing to the confiscation of his notes. He eventually escaped China by literally walking across the border, making his way to Hanoi and catching a plane to Berlin where he was welcomed and now gives lectures. Other recommended books by Liao that are banned in China include: *God is Red: The Secret Story of How Christianity Survived and Flourished in Communist China; The Corpse Walker: Real Life Stories: China From the Bottom Up; and Bullets and Opium*: *Real-Life Stories of China After the Tiananmen Square Massacre.*

Reviewing *Red Scare: Blacklists, McCarthyism, and the Making of Modern America* (August 2025)

Clay Risen, *New York Times* reporter and historian, in his new book argues that the hard right of 2025 America is a direct descendant of the hard right of the 1950s McCarthy era. While he does not invoke the term 'extremist,' over the course of the book, it becomes clear enough that for him the politics of the hard right are extreme. (This is ironic, because for McCarthyites, Communists were considered the extremists of the Left.) For Risen, the anti-Communist, anti-New Deal and anti-Warren Court political views of the McCarthy era conform genealogically to the anti-progressivism and nativism of modern America, although he does not go back and forth between the 1950s and the 2020s to identify and expand upon the similarities. He maintains that his book is "a work of history, and as such it is not concerned with drawing parallels between the past and the present." Risen is mostly careful to eschew polemics, making but a single reference, and that in the Preface, to Trumpism and the MAGA movement. Nevertheless, he seems confident that the history of the Red Scare and the McCarthy era will speak for itself, and he has already committed himself to the assertion that "there was a throughline to be found running from the era of the Red Scare to our current political moment."(1)

Though written 30 years later than Griffin Fariello's oral history of the Red Scare (*Red Scare: Memories of the American Inquisition,* 1995), Risen's history shares the belief that the McCarthy era was in large part a conservative reaction to the New Deal of President Franklin Delano Roosevelt (FDR), the stirring of the civil rights movement and the threat of an emerging alternative to capitalism. Republicans having been out of the White House since 1932 feared forever losing the good old days, hence, the intensity of McCarthyites. Of these, Risen writes that, "there were many Americans who felt that the New Deal had in fact forgotten them:

the small-town middle class, the religious fundamentalists, the avowed white supremacists who continued to insist that America was a country founded by and for Northern Europeans."

In addition to domestic issues, both authors acknowledge that geopolitics had taken a abrupt turn after World War II. The U.S. and the U.S.S.R. were the dominant great powers—the British and French empires were in decline and China was re-engaged in a long-running civil war. The U.S.S.R. was perceived to be a threat as its form of government was incompatible with democratic governments in the West insofar as the alternative political economy of state control in the U.S.S.R. conflicted sharply with limited government and free enterprise in America. The Truman Doctrine declared war— a Cold War—on the U.S.S.R. Republicans and Democrats(2) were aligned on foreign policy vis-à-vis the U.S.S.R. And, as both authors note, both major parties were concerned about the domestic threat of Communism. President Truman, a Democrat, and President Eisenhower, a Republican, each had lists of subversive organizations with their respective Attorneys General, and both established loyalty programs to ensure that Communists were not infiltrating American institutions.

According to Risen, the confluence of "two powerful impulses coursing through American society"—the conflict between conservative and progressive philosophies and the new danger of nuclear war—"unleashed an unprecedented period of political hysteria."

By the early 1950s, Risen observes,

> Tens of thousands of American soldiers were dying in Korea, Communists controlled China, the Soviets had detonated an atomic bomb, and millions feared another global conflagration was at hand. Fathers dug bomb

> shelters in their backyards. Teachers drilled their students on how to take cover under their desks in the event of a surprise Soviet attack, not just in big cities but in thousands of small towns across Middle America. Hollywood churned out movies like *I Married a Communist*, *I Was a Communist for the FBI*, and *Big Jim McLain*, in which John Wayne played a HUAC investigator hunting reds in Hawaii. Syndicated columnists like George Sokolsky and Westbrook Pegler, read by millions every week, made militant anti-Communism their signature story.

Risen does not deny that there were American spies whose sympathies lay with the Communist Party. Based on the decrypted Venona files(3), he admits that there is,

> [C]ompelling proof that figures like [Alger] Hiss and the Rosenbergs [Julius and Ethel] and the leadership of the American Communist Party had, in fact, worked for the Soviet Union and against the United States. There was substance to concerns about Soviet infiltration. But it remained clear that the response, in the form of blacklists and congressional investigations and book bans and loyalty tests, went so far beyond what was necessary that something else was in the mix. Explaining that "something else" became a driving force for this book.

That 'something else' is in part related to what has already been mentioned, viz., the anti-progressivism of the hard right that rejected FDR's New Deal, was opposed to upsetting the racial imbalance in America and feared the emergence of a competing ideology to American capitalism. But this 'something else' also refers to the means by which this political shift was effected. The curtailment and even abrogation of civil liberties was repeated over and over again from the Truman years through McCarthy years. The Bill of Rights' protections of free speech, free association and

due process were ostensibly sacrificed in the interest of national security. However, the agenda of the hard right was simultaneously advanced and not just as a fortuitous outcome. In other words, the hard right conspired to use the alleged Communist conspiracy to violently overthrow the government of the U.S. in order to reverse the gains made by progressives during the FDR administrations from 1932-1945. Risen makes two references to the “deep state” of modern American politics and demonstrates that he is, in fact, unable to avoid drawing parallels between the 1950s and contemporary America. The Communist penetration of American government during the Red Scare, real but exaggerated, would correspond to what today is considered the “deep state.”

Risen does not buy into the “deep state” conspiracy. He sees something quite different from an incipient Bolshevik-like coup.

> On the surface, America in the early 1950s was *I Love Lucy* and Levittown and bowling leagues and bobby socks. Underneath it was seething, fearful, angry. Those who wanted more change—feminists, civil rights activists, antiwar organizers, gay people—were not just out of tune with the times; they were, of a sudden, considered dangerous to the commonweal. . . . The country was going feral.

He sees a large body of disaffected Americans looking for something different from what they found in their modern world. They yearned for a return to a more comfortable time and place, and McCarthyism obligingly appeared on stage at the just the ‘right’ moment in history.

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Endnotes

(1) In the Preface he quotes Albert Camus from *The Plague*: “plague bacillus never dies or disappears for good; that it can lie dormant for years and years in furniture and linen chests; that it bides its time in bedrooms, cellars, trunks, and bookshelves.” And to make sure that there is no misunderstanding his reference, he follows the quote with these words: “Something similar happened in the 1950s, which is to say also the 1960s and ’70s and, I believe, on up through today. There is a lineage to the American hard right of today.”

(2) The new Progressive Party, represented in the 1948 presidential election by Henry Wallace, FDR’s Vice-President during his third term, was out of step with the two major parties. Its platform called for peaceful coexistence with the U.S.S.R. The Communist Party of America’s endorsement of Wallace probably did not help given the mood of the nation. Wallace received less than three percent of the popular vote and failed to carry a single state in the electoral college.

(3) Venona was a secret government counterespionage program that intercepted, decrypted and then translated Soviet communications. The first files to be made public were only released in 1995.

Reviewing *East West Street* (August 2025)

Philippe Sands, highly regarded as an academic, public intellectual and litigator before international courts, published *East West Street: On the Origins of "Genocide" and "Crimes Against Humanity"* in 2016.(1) International criminal law is the central theme of the book, and Sands situates the arguments for including crimes against humanity and genocide in the new post-World War II international order in time, place and its early advocates. However, by no means is the book a legal text with extensive case notes and references. It is a story, a sort of detective story, as one man, Sands, tries to piece together his family's past starting from Lviv, a city in western Ukraine where he had been invited to give a lecture on international law in 2010. As he investigates the history of his family, he makes connections between his family and two of the most famous international jurists of the 20th century. For Sands, discovery culminates in the judgment of the International Military Tribunal at Nuremberg in 1946.

The four main characters in the book are Hersch Lauterpacht, Rafael Lemkin, Leon Buchholz and Hans Frank, and because of its place in the history of Sands' family and the development of post-World War II international law, he suggests that Lviv (Lwów in independent Poland between the world wars, Lemberg under the Austrians and Nazis and Lviv since Ukrainian independence in 1991) could be added as a fifth character.

Lviv is a medium-sized city in Central Europe whose name has changed multiple times as its 'ownership' has changed hands many times, with the Austro-Hungarian Empire, Poland, Germany, the U.S.S.R. and currently Ukraine each laying claim to it at one time or another. It is the common geographic point of contact for the author and his four principal characters. Leon, his maternal grandfather, and for Sands, the smiling boy with big ears in one of the family

photos, is the only person from his extended family of 70 or more in Lemberg and Żółkiew (now Zhovkva in Ukraine) to survive the Nazi murders. Lauterpacht and Lemkin studied law at the university in Lemberg and Lwów, respectively, under some of the same professors though not at the same time. Hans Frank was the Nazi governor of the General Government (Nazi-occupied Poland). At the Nuremberg trials, Frank is the target of the new laws on mass murder. In reality, he is but one of the targets, although a very important one.

Lauterpacht and Lemkin are credited with advancing the body of international law to recognize and incorporate the definition and punishment of mass killing. At the time, their views were contrary. For Lauterpacht, the individual not the group must be the focus. As Sands writes,

> [H]e saw firsthand how the law's desire to protect some groups—as reflected in the Polish Minorities Treaty—could create a sharp backlash. Poorly crafted laws could have unintended consequences, provoking the very wrongs they sought to prevent. I was instinctively sympathetic to Lauterpacht's view, which was motivated by a desire to reinforce the protection of each individual, irrespective of which group he or she happened to belong to, to limit the potent force of tribalism, not reinforce it. By focusing on the individual, not the group, Lauterpacht wanted to diminish the force of intergroup conflict. It was a rational, enlightened view, and also an idealistic one.

And then presenting Lemkin's argument,(2) Sands writes

> The counterargument was put most strongly by Lemkin. Not opposed to individual rights, he nevertheless believed that an excessive focus on individuals was naive, that it ignored the reality of conflict and violence: individuals were

> targeted because they were members of a particular group, not because of their individual qualities. For Lemkin, the law must reflect true motive and real intent, the forces that explained why certain individuals—from certain targeted groups—were killed. For Lemkin, the focus on groups was the practical approach.

In brief, according to Sands,

> Lauterpacht and Lemkin were sharply divided as to the solutions they proposed to a big question: How could the law help to prevent mass killing? Protect the individual, says Lauterpacht. Protect the group, says Lemkin.

Today, both crimes against humanity and genocide are part of international law.

In hindsight, it seems unlikely that these new laws regarding mass killing would have been adopted but for the Holocaust. The enormity of the crimes demanded a commensurate and international response, and the four Allied powers—the U.S., Great Britain, France and the U.S.S.R.—were, at the end of the war, still united and determined to prosecute and punish the Nazi leadership. Similarly, the magnitude of death and destruction of World War I and World War II compelled the victors of those wars to establish the League of Nations and the United Nations, respectively, as part of a new international order. That effort to prevent a second world war failed miserably after World War I. Thus far, the great powers have not plunged World War III.

Lauterpacht and Lemkin had very different responses to the Nuremburg tribunal's judgment on October 1, 1946. The tribunal agreed with Lauterpacht's arguments on crimes against humanity. Individual criminal responsibility for the worst crimes during wartime were no longer automatically precluded by the sovereignty claims

of the state. However, there was no mention in the judgment of genocide despite Lemkin's best efforts to have it included. "Lemkin was equally horrified that the crimes committed before the war were entirely ignored," because this ignored the genocidal acts of the 1930s as if to say that genocide can only be committed during wartime.

But Lemkin, ever the nuisance for many, never capitulated, and he continued to lobby to have the crime of genocide integrated into international law. Two years after the Nuremberg judgment, there was movement. The U.N. General Assembly took up the question of genocide and passed the *Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide.* One day later, the General Assembly adopted the *Universal Declaration of Human Rights*. Lemkin's and Lauterpacht's visions for an improved international humanitarian law were being realized after many years of hard work.

In a victory both Lauterpacht and Lemkin could be pleased to have participated in, the Nuremberg tribunal tried, convicted and sentenced twelve defendants to death. Ten of them were executed by hanging. Martin Bormann was tried, convicted and sentenced *in absentia* and Hermann Göring committed suicide just before his scheduled execution. Adolf Hitler, Joseph Goebbels and Heinrich Himmler had already committed suicide before the trials. This was a singular moment for the international community (albeit as represented only by the four nations prosecuting the Nuremberg cases) in holding a state and its principals accountable for wartime atrocities.

In the Epilogue, Sands cites a number of cases where the new international laws on crimes against humanity and genocide have been applied. However, unaddressed is the fact that none of the indictments or convictions Sands mentions were made against

powerful states and/or their citizens. The victors of World War II (U.S., U.K., France, U.S.S.R./Russia and China), now ensconced as permanent members of the U.N. Security Council, with absolute veto powers, are effectively beyond the jurisdiction of international courts.

Here, Sands brings the reader back to the mystery of his family's disappearance. East-west street in Żółkiew, about 30 km north of Lwów in Ukraine, is the geographic point of connection between Sands and Lauterpacht. Lauterpacht and Sands's great-grandmother lived at opposite ends of the town, on east-west street. Żółkiew is also significant, because it is the location of the book's final scene, where Sands visits a nearby forest just outside the town. On March 25, 1943, the Germans executed 3,500 civilians (Jews) in a clearing of oaks and birches where the children of Żółkiew used to play.

> Among the bones that lay beneath [the dark ponds] was a commingling, Leon's uncle Leibus, Lauterpacht's uncle David, resting near each other in this place because they happened to be a member of the wrong group.

Earlier, Sands seems inclined towards Lauterpacht's insistence that the individual be the focus of the law. But what he sees in the woods of Żółkiew is visceral, and he then intellectualizes as follows,

> [The sense of group identity] poses a serious challenge for our system of international law confronted with a tangible tension: on the one hand, people are killed because they happen to be members of a certain group; on the other, the recognition of that fact by the law tends to make more likely the possibility of conflict between groups, by reinforcing the sense of group identity. Perhaps Leopold Kohr got it right, in the strong but private letter he wrote to

> his friend Lemkin, that the crime of genocide will end up giving rise to the very conditions it seeks to ameliorate.

By the end of the book, the Sands retains his preference for the human rights approach of the ‘crimes of humanity’ label, but he also seems more inclined to accept Lemkin’s concept of ‘genocide.’ At this point, the reader is encouraged to listen to Ezra Klein’s interview(3) with Philippe Sands on the question, ‘When Is It Genocide?’ Sands shares his views on crimes against humanity and genocide nine years after *East West Street*. In addition, there are sufficient references from which the reader can get a synopsis of the book. Even so, the reader may still wish to read the book. It is a worthwhile and engrossing read.

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Endnotes

(1) Sands is the author of *Lawless World: America and the Making and Breaking of Global Rules* (2005), which remains as relevant in 2025 as it was during America’s War on Terror during the George W. Bush Administration.

(2) According to Sands, Lemkin said that he had begun thinking about the destruction of groups at around age 18 (end of WWI). This was three years after the beginning of the Armenian Genocide in the Ottoman Empire. Thus, Sands is able to demonstrate that Lemkin’s views on genocide were developing well before the Holocaust.

The following excerpt from *Axis Rule in Occupied Europe* (1944) encapsulates Lemkin’s view on this new concept of ‘genocide.’

> New conceptions require new terms. By "genocide" we mean the destruction of a nation or of an ethnic

> group. This new word, coined by the author to denote an old practice in its modern development, is made from the ancient Greek word genos (race, tribe) and the Latin tide (killing), thus corresponding in its formation to such words as tyrannicide, homocide[sic], infanticide, etc. Generally speaking, genocide does not necessarily mean the immediate destruction of a nation, except when accomplished by mass killings of all members of a nation. It is intended rather to signify a coordinated plan of different actions aiming at the destruction of essential foundations of the life of national groups, with the aim of annihilating the groups themselves. The objectives of such a plan would be disintegration of the political and social institutions, of culture, language, national feelings, religion, and the economic existence of national groups, and the destruction of the personal security, liberty, health, dignity, and even the lives of the individuals belonging to such groups. Genocide is directed against the national group as an entity, and the actions involved are directed against individuals, not in their individual capacity, but as members of the national group.

(3) The recording and transcript of the interview are available online at: https://www.nytimes.com/2025/08/13/opinion/ezra-klein-podcast-philippe-sands.html.

Reviewing *Ungoverning* (September 2025)

‘Ungoverning’ is the term Russell Muirhead and Nancy Rosenblum use to describe “the attack on the capacity and legitimacy of government, especially the part of government that goes by the term ‘administrative state.’” The ‘administrative state’ is the government bureaucracy, that “vast array of government agencies that shape, implement, adjudicate, and enforce public policies of every kind.”(1) Muirhead is Professor of Democracy and Politics at Dartmouth College, and Rosenblum is Professor of Ethics in Politics and Government Emerita at Harvard University. In 2024, they published *Ungoverning: The Attack on the Administrative State and the Politics of Chaos*.

The authors’ writings on ungoverning are part of a fairly recent spate of literature describing the contemporary challenges faced by liberal democracies worldwide. The adjective ‘liberal’ is important because it makes clear that the democratic state does not possess unlimited powers.(2) In a liberal democracy, a constitution establishes the ground rules for governance, enumerating the responsibilities of the various agencies of the state and defining the limits of state power vis-à-vis individuals. In an illiberal or authoritarian democracy, elections are not vigorously contested, and the authority of the executive body of the state is expansive with respect to what we call the separation of powers as well as individual civil liberties. Unsurprisingly, this concentration of power in the executive of necessity includes control over the election process itself. The authors cite Viktor Orbán’s Hungary, Hugo Chávez’s Venezuela and Narendra Modi’s India as examples of authoritarian democracies.(3)

The book covers Trump’s first term in office as well as his actions and pronouncements as former president during the Biden administration. The compelling evidence the authors submit in

support of their analysis and assessment of the ungoverning threat against America is even greater in Trump's second term. In their most recently published collaboration, 'Ungoverning America: The Logic Behind Trump's Assault on the Administrative State' published September 5, 2025 in *Foreign Affairs*, they write that "ungoverning has become the core logic of the Republican Party that Trump now dominates. It is thus not surprising that Trump's second-term agenda centers on tearing Washington apart."

The authors attempt to distinguish fascism from ungoverning. Acknowledging the value of the charge of 'fascism' for mobilizing resistance against Trump, they argue that "fascist foreboding can be misleading." For instance, they write that

> In [Nazi] Germany, the bureaucratic apparatus was taken over and redirected. Ungoverning does not strengthen and redirect bureaucracy, it incapacitates the state. . . . [T]he reactionary movement [MAGA] and the Republican Party have neither capacity nor inclination for totalist ideology. The aim is to destroy constraints; it is not to do, it is to undo.

Ungoverning has also been described as "Lenin dismantling the institutions," a not so subtle reference to Vladimir Lenin's famous proclamation that under Communism, the state will wither away. But ungoverning is not a preliminary stage to reform; it is destruction, in America's case, of the liberal democratic system of government. What comes next is authoritarian populism.

In America, the purpose of ungoverning is to establish the personal rule of one man, Donald J. Trump. The legislature, the courts and the bureaucracy all have to be forced into submission to the president. Separation of powers, checks and balances, expertise, (non-arbitrary) proceduralism, a mutually respected two-party

political system—all of these must bend to the demands of the chief executive of the moment.

The authors add that uncontested personal rule is prone to corruption, writing that “Trump’s own zeal for personal enrichment encouraged something more comprehensive that looked like a “lawless feeding frenzy, [which] [w]e might see it as incipient kleptocracy.”(4)

Trump’s power lies in his control of the MAGA movement. It is by means of this movement that Trump was able to take control of the Republican Party, and it was his domination of the party and its membership that enabled him to maneuver Congress effectively enough to pass Reagan-like tax cuts, fend off two impeachment convictions and appoint enough loyal justices to control the Supreme Court. In his second term, Trump has accelerated and intensified his war on the administrative state, which the authors regard as the last stronghold of the progressive politics that have shaped modern America since the New Deal era. This is the so-called Deep State that is legally obligated to execute extant U.S. law even if the laws’ interventionist and regulatory socioeconomic and business philosophy is anathema to the White House of the day.

What distinguishes Trump’s America is that it is “a twisted version of democracy” where “the connection between the leader and the people is direct, personal, immediate, and emotional.” For a populist authoritarian such as Trump,

> The leader’s relation to followers requires his constant presence, with ceremonial occasions that stage the strongman signing orders or appearing with military officers, with frequent rallies, and with a never-ending stream of tweets. The people are constantly present to the

> leader, and, importantly, the leader is present to them. He understands and shares his followers' antipathies and their desire for action "right now." He cultivates a dynamic of constant, mutual recognition.

Here, the authors quote the Italian political theorist and Columbia professor of political science, Nadia Urbinati, who makes the point somewhat more succinctly: "the populist leader needs to stay in permanent campaign mode because . . . the formality of elections has less value than the strength of the audience."

This day-to-day manipulation of his 'audience' is what enables Trump to keep the Republican Party membership loyal and obedient. What has so far worked best for Trump in animating and deploying his populist base is the promise of a restoration—Make American Great Again—of the white Christian nation to replace the weak America that subscribes to multiculturalism, pluralism, secularism and international rules. His followers give their loyalty in exchange for his recognition of and promise to redress their grievances. And their loyalty extends to employing extralegal violence as the January 6th Insurrection, notwithstanding the U.S. military's refusal, at that point in history, to interfere in the election on President Trump's behalf.

The strength of his base—upwards of 70 million based on voting in the 2020 presidential election—is the leverage that he wields against enemies and to corral his opportunistic supporters. The Republicans, in turn, take their orders from Trump and attack whomever and wherever he directs. Although not mentioned in the book, one of the more alarming examples of Republican fealty to Trump was demonstrated when the Republican House launched an impeachment investigation against President Biden, in retaliation for the Democratic House's double impeachment of Trump. The insult to Trump was not assuaged by the genuflecting Republican

senators who refused to convict Trump on the articles of impeachment.

The Republican's primary objective is to prevent the Democrats from governing (at the federal, state and local level), silence Trump's opponents and deny federal agencies the freedom to act consonant with their professional expertise and approved standards if the president so wishes. And perhaps no other American has made more effective use of the courts to intimidate his opponents, escape justice (he is, until pardoned, an unsentenced convicted felon) and win virtual immunity from prosecution from the highest court in the land. And this court, the U.S. Supreme Court under Chief Justice John Roberts with six Trump supporters, is promoting the unitary executive doctrine, whereby the President, under Article II of the Constitution, is entitled to exercise absolute authority over the executive branch and all of its subordinate and even independent agencies. The objective: to consolidate executive authority in the Office of the President, so that the president can dismiss agency staff and appoint their replacements with ease as a means of compelling agencies to follow presidential directives. Thus, the Fed could be commanded to lower interest rates prior to an election, the SEC could be ordered to investigate a company owned by an enemy of the president, the FCC could be directed to revoke the licenses of unfriendly networks, the FEC could be forced to investigate an opposition candidate in a presidential election, the FBI could be made to investigate a political opponent, and the IRS could be coerced into auditing whomever the president chose.

For Americans who do not view government bureaucracy favourably—its convoluted immensity, inefficient workings and officious airs—the alternative of a presidentially-micromanaged bureaucracy carrying out the whims and fancies of one man surely must be worse.

In the authors' most recent update to *Ungoverning*, they report a state of affairs in American government that is arguably even more extreme than the first Trump administration.

> In the first seven months of his second term, U.S. President Donald Trump has made unprecedented changes to the way the American government operates. He has launched an extraordinary and erratic tariff scheme, eliminated U.S. foreign aid programs, upended U.S. alliances, and waged war on the administrative state. He has detained and deported scores of foreign students and scholars for their political views; strong-armed universities, law firms, corporations, and media outlets into doing his bidding; and emasculated the government's regulatory agencies. He has deployed the U.S. National Guard to Los Angeles and Washington, D.C., purportedly to fight disorder and crime, and threatened to send the military to Chicago, New York City, and beyond. ('Ungoverning America,' *Foreign Affairs*)

Trump's relentless pursuit of 'ungovernance' represents "the comprehensive and intentional destruction of state capacity." In its wake, Trump's personal rule, founded on a large, vocal populist base, exemplifies the motto attributed to Louis XIV, the 17th century absolute monarch of France: *L'état, C'est moi.* Such an assertion would not be out of character for Trump who has expressed enthusiastic envy for the perpetual regimes of Vladimir Putin and Xi Jinping.

The authors' outlook is grim. In their parting words, they write "The shadow ungoverning casts over American political life will remain until citizens appreciate and assert the necessity for institutions that give government the capacity to govern." "Appreciate and assert"—that is so vague that it might imply a wide range of possible responses, some of which the authors probably wouldn't care to

publicly endorse. It seems to this reviewer to be a fatuous statement to make at the conclusion of a damning analysis of Trump's presidency and a dismal assessment of the prospects for liberal democracy in America.

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Endnotes

(1) The authors concede that there is very often little sympathy for the bureaucracy. They point to the common unpleasant experience of dealing with a government bureaucracy, citing in particular the dreaded state-run departments of motor vehicles and the IRS. Then, too, there are the ubiquitous "literary portraits of men and women in the maws of [a coercive and irrational] bureaucracy that engender fear and loathing.

But the authors are quick to observe that laws are not self-executing. Therefore, "everything that is required to give laws content and bring them into the world is administration—and much of it is unseen."

(2) 'Liberal' as used in the term 'liberal democracy' simply refers to the liberty of the individual from all-encompassing state power. It does not refer to either the generous or the libertine.

(3) For a global overview, see Anne Applebaum's *Autocracy, Inc.: The Dictators Who Want to Run the World* (2024). Others have written that the longstanding view in the West that a capitalist economic system and a democratic political system are inevitably paired is flawed and that, in fact, there is a fundamental dissonance between capitalist individualism and democratic community. China's astonishing rise from a Third World state to a global superpower has led many to rethink the assumption that capitalism needs democracy. See Martin Wolf's T*he Crisis of Democratic Capitalism*

(2023) and Quinn Slobodian's *Crack-Up Capitalism: Market Radicals and the Dream of a World Without Democracy* (2023).

(4) See Casey Michel's article, 'America Has Never Seen Corruption Like This' published July 10, 2025 in *The Atlantic*, in which Michel asserts that "Trump 2.0 is just getting started, yet it already represents the high-water mark of American kleptocracy." Michel is the author of *American Kleptocracy: How the U.S. Created the World's Greatest Money Laundering Scheme in History* (2021).

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Glossary of Acronyms and Abbreviations for U.S. Agencies

FEC - Federal Election Commission
Fed - Federal Reserve System
FCC - Federal Communications Commission
FBI - Federal Bureau of Investigation
IRS - Internal Revenue Service
SEC - Securities and Exchange Commission

Reviewing *The Crooked Timber of Democracy in Israel* (October 2025)

In her 2023 book, *The Crooked Timber of Democracy in Israel: Promise Unfulfilled*, Dahlia Scheindlin, a Tel Aviv-based political analyst, raises questions about the degree to which Israel can claim to be both a liberal democracy and a Jewish state. She argues that the democratic foundations of Israel, even those pre-dating the State of Israel, were weak and compromised. The book's title, drawn from these words from Immanuel Kant—"out of the crooked timber of humanity no straight thing was ever made"—alludes to Scheindlin's thesis. In a way, this suggests a defensiveness on the part of the author, but over the course of the book, she presents compelling historical evidence that supports a critical though not lethal assessment of Israel's experiment with democracy. In her concluding paragraph, she restates her assertion that "Israel will not become democratic until realizing that the problem lies in its very roots," but then she pulls back from utopian envisioning and says simply, "we *can* do better."

Nevertheless, throughout the book, Scheindlin consistently holds Israel to a high standard. For her, it isn't sufficient that Israel is said to be the only democracy in the Middle East. And from her occasional but brief digressions into the world's 21st century illiberal democracies, it is clear that she believes Israel should aspire to the ideals of democratic governance despite—and in fact because of—the backsliding of many Western democracies. Earlier on in the book, her critique of Israel could just as easily have been applied to the U.S. where religion overreaches into politics, majoritarianism steamrolls ethnic diversity and consolidation of authority in the state executive is driven by a lust for power and immunity from criticism and countervailing powers … not least, from criminal prosecution. Therefore, notwithstanding her stated disavowal of utopian democratic expectations, she is hard-pressed

in current times to find a useful liberal democracy exemplar, one that has successfully pushed back against illiberal populist and authoritarian threats. Hence, her somewhat idealistic assumptions.

The early decades between independence and the Six-Day War were characterized by many of the democratic challenges that continue to confront Israeli democracy. For instance, “the military regime governing much of the Arab population is not marginal to the story of democracy in Israel—not in the early years, or even in the decades after it ended.” And from the beginning, “[t]he practice of achieving religious concessions by threatening coalition stability . . . became routine in Israel and represents a pronounced feature of Israeli politics” demonstrating how religious parties have maintained disproportionate political influence.(1) Third, “The missing bill of rights is a gaping hole in the democratic foundations of Israel’s early decades,” and a complete and undisputed bill of rights remains elusive. Fourth, though Arabs had voter franchise during the military regime (from 1948-1966), “Electoral participation for Arabs lacked any of the civil liberties associated with a ‘free and fair’ process,” effectively rolling back universal suffrage. Fifth, the role of the judiciary has from the outset not been recognized as a legitimate arbiter of the rule of law, and its status remains uncertain. Sixth, Scheindlin writes that

> One of the least visible elements of the regime left an enduring, collective psychological imprint even decades later: surveillance. Informers were essential to the regime. The military government coerced, bought, bribed, and blackmailed informers by dangling vital resources that citizens needed to survive, such as movement permits, jobs, and privileges.

One highly significant area where there appears to be longstanding and deep consensus among Israelis is in the view of the state’s role

in the economy. As Scheindlin notes, by the 1992 election, “the economy had become significantly more liberal, less statist, and more privatized since the mid-1980s, the major parties still supported the basic welfare state that put Israel in the camp of social democracies, rather than American-style capitalism.”

Probably the most contentious aspect of this work is the inclusion of the Occupied Territories. Early on in the book, Scheindlin makes clear that she is writing about Israel and the Occupied Territories as one entity and not just ‘Israel proper.’

> [W]hen evaluating democratic practice in Israel, I have chosen to consider all people and territory under Israeli control. This is not an arbitrary decision—I believe that the historical analysis of Israeli policy demonstrates that the control of the land and population of the Occupied Territories is inseparable from Israeli governance and society.

With this decision, Scheindlin enlarges the scope of her analysis to include direct comparisons between the democratic freedoms granted to Israeli citizens and denied to Palestinian non-citizens. At the time of publication, Scheindlin notes that “Israel’s population is over 9.7 million, and it controls, directly or indirectly, over 5 million Palestinians in the West Bank, Gaza, and East Jerusalem through various undemocratic mechanisms.” In her view, the occupation is largely, but not entirely, responsible for Israel’s democratic deficit.

There are, of course, other contributing causes. One not mentioned so far is the level of income inequality and poverty in ‘Israel proper.’ Scheindlin writes that, Netanyahu, the leader of Likud, has been shrewd in exploiting populist anger and frustration with the elites, particularly those traditionally associated with the Ashkenazi-ruled

Labor Party. Netanyahu is himself one of those elites albeit as a leader of the rival Likud Party.

> The losers of this growing inequality, not surprisingly, were those who had historically found themselves at the lower end of the Israeli economic and social structure. Among Jews, this largely meant Mizrahi Jews and the ultra-Orthodox—both groups that vote mostly for right-wing or religious parties.

Scheindlin cites OECD statistics that describe the levels of income inequality and poverty, but regrettably she uses dated information (from 2013 and 2014). The most recent online statistics from the OECD show that Israel's income inequality and poverty levels are above the OECD average.(2) Compared with North America, these figures indicate that Israel does not perform as well as Canada but does best both the U.S. and Mexico. It is important to keep in mind that these OECD statistics apply to the State of Israel, thus excluding economic data for the Occupied Territories, which would worsen Israel’s economic inequality data.

Scheindlin’s book ends in 2023 just as the fierce debates and massive public protests over judicial reform were taking place in Israel. “The demonstrations snowballed to hundreds of thousands who turned up every Saturday night, in Tel Aviv, Jerusalem, and other cities and towns throughout the country” to protest the Netanyahu government’s plans “to gut judicial independence, stack the judicial appointment committee with coalition figures, and ban judicial review of Basic Laws.”

And then the events of 10/7 happened. The story that she tells of Netanyahu threatening to rein in the Supreme Court despite mass public outrage—although welcomed by Israel’s religious right and those opposed to an assertive Court inclined to egalitarian

overrides of Knesset laws—is unsettling given the horrors of that day and the ensuing years. The war in Gaza changed the agenda. The constitutional struggle over the conflicting assertions of power by the Knesset and the Court has been backburnered. Netanyahu has regained control over Israeli politics as a wartime prime minister, and everything else, including the corruption indictments, is secondary to the war effort. But that is for another book.

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Endnotes

(1) In order to win the Jewish religious parties' support for the Partition Plan, a status quo agreement was reached. According to Scheindlin, this "would prove fateful for the long-term character of Israeli society." The status quo ensured that the Sabbath would be a day or rest, all public establishments would keep kosher, family law would be governed by religious law and religious education would remain autonomous. Later yeshiva students would be exempted from military service.

(2) See the OECD Economic Surveys: Israel 2025, published April 2, 2025; the OECD Income distribution database accessed October 4, 2025; and the OECD Poverty Gap accessed October 4, 2025.

Reviewing *The Two Faces of American Freedom* (December 2025)

Aziz Rana is a professor of constitutional law at Boston College. His most recent book is *The Constitutional Bind: How Americans Came to Idolize a Document that Fails Them*, published in 2024. A review of that book is included in my *Artifacts of a Troubled and Troublesome Species* published in 2025. In the review, I wrote that one of the book's shortcomings was that while Rana addresses the threat to representative government represented by the Supreme Court, he fails to give sufficient space to the dangers of presidentialism. After having just read *The Two Faces of American Freedom*, it is reassuring to find that Rana had previously addressed the exceptional presidency. In *Two Faces*, he writes

> The idea of a direct representative relationship between president and people-at the heart of Roosevelt's democratic vision of the new social welfare state fundamentally undermined the Federalist theory of democracy, particularly the notion that no existing body or branch of government enjoyed sovereign power.

Reading these words 11 years later, it seems Rana was prescient. President Donald Trump has arguably perfected the strategy of bypassing Congress and the Court by appealing to public sentiment.(1) But in 2014 when *Two Faces* was published, Trump had not yet even appeared on the national political scene as a viable presidential candidate. Thus, for Rana, not a MAGA (Make America Great Again) supporter, a disproportionately powerful president should concern us no matter their political stripe. It should not matter whether the man in the White House who can do something about everything is *our man*.

Rana's book doesn't anticipate Trump populism of the second half of the 2010s and the mid-2020s, although it could easily

incorporate these years as yet another manifestation of white supremacy, Christian fundamentalism and xenophobia at home and continued American use of military and economic power to extract concessions from other countries (minus the humanitarian blind). What Rana calls the plebiscitary presidency is manifest in the FDR (Franklin Delano Roosevelt) presidency, a period reviled as anathema to the present day by conservatives, but with little imagination, it could apply just as well to the Trump years, which represent a political dystopia for establishment and progressive Democrats. For Rana, the plebiscitary president is the logical extension of the ever-ascending dominance of the presidency at the expense of the other two branches of the federal government. As he notes, the powers of the presidency in foreign affairs roughly corresponds to the end of the settlement of the Western Frontier, and the escalation of the president's authority in domestic affairs is traceable to the federal government's response to the economic emergency of the Great Depression. Rana's conventional history of America maps the path to presidential preeminence and even locates its precedent with the 18th century Hanover kings who reigned over the British Empire.

So far, there does not appear to be anything particularly novel in Rana's account. Nevertheless, he does acknowledge that his is "not a work of traditional historical scholarship . . . [but] a form of social criticism. In other words, he is partisan, fearing that what Arthur Schlesinger labeled the imperial presidency—the accretion of near absolute presidential authority in foreign policy and in particular in waging war, as, for example, in Vietnam from the 1950s through the early 1970s. What is relatively new and rather more controversial as historiography is his advocacy for a return to the types of inclusive direct democracy that have faded away into America's past. The populist, progressive and socialist alternatives largely disappeared in the early part of the 20th century. As Rana maintains, in its early years, "the civil rights movement has

embodied the most sustained effort to revive both the vision of liberty as self-rule and to connect this vision with a critique of empire," but that "legacy is almost entirely forgotten" as emphasis has shifted to the "social mobility for middle-class blacks and inclusion for some into arenas of corporate, professional, and political power."

In view of the increasing interest in postcolonial studies, an important contribution that Rana adds to the traditional historiography of America is his analytical treatment of America as a settler society of principally Anglo Caucasians. He rejects the American claims to uniqueness and millennialism, and instead links the qualities of white settler colonialism in American to the "French in Algeria, the English in Northern Ireland, the European Jewish community in Israel/Palestine, and the Chinese in Taiwan" He argues that these characteristics include

> [G]reater equality within the settler colony than in the imperial metropole or home country; a cultural sense of being "chosen" as an ethnic or religious community for a historical mission; a greater emphasis on militarism due to perceived threats from indigenous and foreign populations; and, finally, a wariness of metropolitan social and political customs, which are depicted at times as corrupt or decadent.

Two Faces does not fully encompass American history to date. It begins with the British colonies on the Eastern Seaboard and concludes with the FDR presidency. That, for him, is sufficient to argue his case that there are two faces to American freedom—those being "our long-standing difficulty in imagining liberty without suppression and free citizenship without the control of subject communities." This, too, is hardly ground-breaking for readers familiar with American history. It is an updated reference to

America's double standard of freedom vis-à-vis internal minorities (native and slave populations) and people of foreign lands (non-whites and Southern Europeans.) What is clearly controversial though is the claim that America has essentially transformed itself into one of those European rivals from whose deadly embrace it desperately struggled. President Washington's admonition in his 1796 farewell address to avoid permanent ('entangling') alliances with European nations, which appears to have been sound advice in light of the Napoleonic Wars of the early 1800s.

Stopping the historical record with the FDR presidency is significant and peculiar given the number of examples of external and internal threats that have since promoted a public desire for a greater sense of safety in a strong, centralized executive. For example, America's post-9/11 failed wars in Iraq and Afghanistan, its selective abridgement of wartime civil liberties (e.g., *habeas corpus*, protection from carceral torture, presumption of innocence) and xenophobic immigration policies, especially with regards to Mexican immigrants—all of these demonstrate America's fears of internal and external weakness and support Rana's thesis.

This book is not nearly as long as *The Constitutional Bind*, but it is dense. Rana's archival research is of the highest quality, and in *Two Faces*, he makes excellent use of extended quotes for a number of historical figures—letting them speak for themselves at just the right moment in his narrative. However, another noticeable limitation of this work is that neither interest group politics nor social media are discussed. This is unfortunate because both can be analyzed and critiqued as important yet imperfect variants of the sort of direct democracy he favours. Perhaps what makes this an enjoyable yet informative read is that it synthesizes a number of currents and crosscurrents in American history and links them up to the present, where the author, as he admits, presents a prescriptive history that was as relevant during Barack Obama's presidency,

when the book was written, as it is now in the time of Trump. In his concluding words, Rana writes

> [O]ne cannot expect that legal reforms aimed at curbing executive authority will succeed as long as Americans accept judgments that view security and the protection from external and internal threat as society's guiding commitments.

According to Rana, throughout its history, from its colonial beginnings to its emergence as a Great Power, America has been morally challenged by its two standards of freedom. Domestically, there is one standard for the entitled majority, who have race, religion and cultural history in common and one for non-white minorities whose cultures and aspirations are regarded as antithetical to the American way. Internationally, there is one standard for Americans (in general) and one for all other foreign peoples. America is indeed Janus-faced with respect to freedom.

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Endnotes

(1) For our purposes, Trump’s performance in the last three presidential elections is a good proxy for measuring the magnitude of his influence with the American public. In 2016, he won 63 million votes, in 2020, that total increased to 74 million and in the 2024 election, his popular vote count increased again, this time to 77 million. To date, only one presidential candidate has collected more than 80 million votes and that was Joe Biden in 2020.

Reviewing *Digital Empires* (January 2026)

Digital Empires: The Global Battle to Regulate Technology published in 2023 presents the 21st digital world as a legal battleground where three 'empires' (the U.S., China and the EU) compete for international leadership. Anu Bradford, Professor of Law at Columbia Law School, specializes in the European Union, global economy, and digital regulation. (Though not spelled out as such in the book, 'digital' refers to content and infrastructure, while the 'Internet' is the communication infrastructure that enables global networking.)

Why 'empires?' Bradford chooses this metaphor to capture the economic, technological and regulatory dominance of these three powers, which by virtue of their geopolitical roles shape the digital world for everyone else. She views the current era of the early 21st century as an age of great power geopolitics, hearkening back to the bipolar world of the Cold War superpower rivalry between the U.S. and the U.S.S.R. The current global order represents a rupture from the 1990s, which were dominated by the U.S. on account of the demise of Soviet communism and the commercialization of the Internet. The briefness of the period of unipolarity is attributable to the rapid ascent of China to superpower status and the emergence of the EU as a regulator of digital technology.

In her comparative analysis of the regulatory regimes of the U.S., EU and China, Bradford focuses on the politics, economics and ultimately law of 21st century digital technology. Thus, Bradford is writing about more than just the technology sectors, consequently her analysis extends to broader political, economic and legal features of today's multipolar world order. While well-researched and objective, the book is normatively oriented to the West, particularly the EU. Bradford is not polemical but she is clear in declaring her preferences.

America’s regulatory model is described as market-driven, China’s as state-driven and the EU's as regulatory-driven. Bradford characterizes all three as capitalist varieties of political economy, since all rely, to varying degrees, on capitalist production, commerce and governance. The U.S. and China are obvious choices for ‘empire’ status, but Bradford argues that the EU, despite its relative weakness vis-à-vis the U.S. in innovation and China vis-à-vis the magnitude of its infrastructure, has assumed the role of global leader in developing, adopting and promoting digital standards, e.g., privacy, moderated online content, competition (antitrust) policy and artificial intelligence.(1)

Borrowing from the terminology of antitrust governance, these empires compete horizontally against one another and vertically vis-à-vis tech firms both domestic and foreign. As international trade, investment and migration have political implications, each empire acts principally according to its national interests, or the national interests of its members in the case of the EU. Thus, competing political interests are translated into competing regulatory policies which in turn lock in competing economic benefits. Ultimately, each jurisdiction is held accountable, to varying degrees, to its body politic. Repeated and massive failure to serve its citizenry is injudicious even in authoritarian regimes. In furthering the development of domestic firms, all three governments demonstrate techno-nationalist features, and state aid (by means of subsidies) is one of the most important. Another more specific example of horizontal competition is afforded by the U.S. trade policy to restrict the sale of certain semiconductor chip technology. In addition to horizontal competition, there is vertical competition between the different governments and technology firms (domestic and foreign). An example of vertical competition is the EU’s antitrust policy enforcement decisions against U.S. tech giants.

Unsurprisingly, the competition among governments, between governments and tech firms and among tech firms fails to produce 'win-win' results for everyone. Critics characterize these regimes as free-trade imperialism (U.S.), surveillance imperialism (China) and regulatory imperialism (EU). Google might be inclined to regard the EU as an imperialist regulator, Americans would generally agree that China protects its domestic firms at the expense of American firms, and the Chinese would maintain that not only does America subsidize its own companies but it also coordinates with other countries to block the export of 'national security' sensitive technology to China. In addition, all three models are criticized for exporting their governance models and imposing their values and agendas on others. Thus, the U.S. and the EU export their humanitarian and democratic values, and the Chinese export their values around conformity, order and social harmony.(2)

With respect to digital content, the U.S. prioritizes free speech(3) while EU places free speech among other fundamental rights such as privacy, personal data protection and protection from hate speech and disinformation. US regulatory orientation is laissez-faire emphasizing innovation and technological progress; EU regulatory orientation is interventionist (but not controlling as in China) prioritizing social goals over tech goals. In response to the criticism that EU regulation stifles innovation, the author counters that the challenges for innovation are much greater in the heterogeneous EU market than they are in the homogeneous US market.

Chinese tech success has debunked two myths: first, that the Internet inherently promotes freedom and second, that tech innovation and progress require laissez-faire regulatory policies. Around the world, countries (autocratic and non-autocratic) have taken notice that the Western model is no longer the sole guide for economic development and technological progress. This has created increasing competition for global leadership between China

on one hand and the U.S. and the EU on the other. China's state-driven regulatory model is increasingly popular as the trend away from democratic governments to autocratic governments continues and as China has demonstrated that economic development and technological progress do not require a democratic political system. China's model of state capitalism combined with censorship and surveillance is attractive to autocratic governments. Meanwhile, China’s Digital Silk Road (part of the Belt and Road Initiative) is appealing to less affluent states who want an alternative infrastructural partner to the U.S.

Bradford predicts a convergence between the U.S. and the EU regulatory governance models, with the US moving closer to the EU's rights-driven approach, rather than the EU shifting towards the US free-market approach. For her, online privacy, content moderation, taxation, antitrust and AI regulation are not only preferable under the EU model,(4) but they are more likely to persist as the market-driven approach in the U.S. may gradually give way under public pressure similar to what the American trusts encountered at the turn of the 20th century.(5)

Looking ahead, Bradford believes that there are two paths by which liberal democracy can degenerate: first, if the U.S. and EU governance models are supplanted by China's and second, if the U.S. and EU lose their respective vertical battles with the tech industry. In China, the vertical relationship between the state and big tech is asymmetric with the state dominating. Such is not the case in the US or the EU. Bradford’s references to omnipotent tech and the global authoritarian turn place this book in the category of warnings about the imminent demise of liberal democratic capitalism.(6)

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Endnotes

(1) The ‘Brussels Effect,’ a term coined by Bradford, is attributable to the population size and relative per capita wealth of the EU market. The size and wealth of the EU market is often enough to compel voluntary compliance by tech firms who for business reasons prefer to have one set of regulations globally instead of multiple regulatory systems for different countries/regions.

(2) In the U.S., individual freedom (especially free speech) and corporate freedom (especially to innovate) are prized, while in China, the state goals of technological progress, economic growth and social harmony predominate.

(3) Bradford makes several references to the January 6th insurrection in the U.S. in 2021 in order to illustrate the unintended consequences of absolute free speech. She is clearly on board with EU free speech norms, which are intended to regulate hate speech and disinformation.

(4) All is not perfect in the EU. Germany and France have always been 1st among equal, and this has created dissension within EU among those who feel that for some national sovereignty and democracy have been compromised by European integration. Furthermore, the EU is not immune to charges of hypocrisy. While the European Commission (the EU’s executive) has taken issue with large foreign mergers going back to its blocking of the GE/Honeywell merger in 2001, the EC is not always unfriendly to EU mergers that result in an EU national champion, as for example in the pharmaceutical industry.

(5) It's important to note that this book was published before the second Trump Administration. While there has recently been strong anti-big tech sentiment in America, this has been tempered by Trump's ultra-nationalism, which paints Big

Tech in a more positive light as American national champions in the global market.

(6) An important issue for the future of technological progress and liberal democracies is missing from this book. There is a common belief among tech firms and governments with respect to potentially harmful technology that ‘we build it, but we do not choose how it will be deployed’ creates plausible immunity from charges of aiding and abetting bad actors whether they are autocrats, terrorists or criminals. In America and elsewhere, this has long been used to defend weapons R&D and sales, so should not surprise anyone that today digital tech uses the same defense. This calls to mind the Bradbury short story, 'The Flying Machine.'

Reviewing *Competitive Authoritarianism* (January 2026)

In its January/February issue, *Foreign Affairs* published an essay entitled, 'The Price of American Authoritarianism: What Can Reverse Democratic Decline?' by Steven Levitsky (Harvard University) and Lucan Way (University of Toronto). The authors argue that "In Trump's second term, the United States has descended into competitive authoritarianism." So, what is 'competitive authoritarianism and how is it different from other forms of authoritarianism? According to Levitsky and Way, [it is] a system in which parties compete in elections but incumbents routinely abuse their power to punish critics and tilt the playing field against their opposition." The key word is 'compete'—there being a possibility that the opposition may actually pull off an upset victory. In 2010, the authors published *Competitive Authoritarianism: Hybrid Regimes After the Cold War* in which they use their model to evaluate competitive authoritarianism in the regimes of 35 countries at the end of the Soviet era.(1)

The authors' definition of democracy is important from the outset. For them, "What distinguishes competitive authoritarianism from democracy . . . is the fact that incumbent abuse of the state violates at least one of three defining attributes of democracy: (1) free elections, (2) broad protection of civil liberties, and (3) a reasonably level playing field." The contrast between their working definition and the more common view that regularly contested elections suffice for a democracy could not be sharper. Accordingly, they believe that "Western democracy promotion was 'electoralist' in that it focused almost exclusively on multiparty elections while often ignoring dimensions such as civil liberties and a level playing field." In other words, there was a prioritization of form over substance.

To protect themselves from the charge of overextending their theory, Levitsky and Lucan limit their analysis and conclusions to

those factors that principally contribute to democratization or maintenance of the status quo. They shy away from claiming that their approach is universal, yet their *Foreign Affairs'* essay suggests that they have since revisited their model and found it to fit contemporary America. Their model outright excludes rigidly authoritarian regimes such as those found in China, Russia, Iran and North Korea. For the term competitive authoritarianism to apply, there has to be a chance, however unlikely, that an opposition party can win an election. This would be impossible in any one of the four countries just mentioned.

What then is distinctive about Levitsky and Lucan's methodology? Here, three terms need to be unpacked: organization power, leverage and linkage. Organization power, which can refer to the state and/or party, refers to an "incumbents' capacity to prevent elite defection, co-opt or repress opponents, defuse or crack down on protest, and win (or steal) elections." Leverage describes the existence and employment of political, economic and military intervention by another country. This often comes to mind when reviewing the history of American foreign policy, but it is equally applicable to the EU's use of membership accession as an incentive for countries to democratize. And, linkage relates to the sum total of economic, intergovernmental, technocratic, social, information and civil-society interactions between those within the borders and the rest of the world, especially the Western world of forbidden freedoms and democratic institutions. In the authors' opinion, there is no substitute for the free movement of people, ideas and trade across borders.

Levitsky and Lucan's analysis suggest that a high linkage with the West corresponds with democratization of competitive authoritarian systems. The authors explain this in terms of raising the costs of authoritarian abuse. Thus, a porous border allows the government's abuse of power to be internationalized and sanctioned, and it

permits international solidarity with the opposition. Both tend to weaken the authoritarian grip. Where high linkage is missing, the probability of sustained democratization is very low. For example, in Eastern Europe and the Americas where linkage with the U.S. and/or EU was high, democratic pressures on competitive authoritarian regimes increased from the both outside and the inside. In Africa, the failure of democratization is largely attributable to low Western linkage. In Africa, it is as if nobody knows what is happening there and nobody cares, so without a powerful external catalyst and no support to sustain a vigorous opposition, democracy remains dormant.

Implicitly, the authors are shaming the U.S. and EU for their negligence. But here, there is also irony, as this book reads as if it might have been commissioned by the U.S. State Department. Its analysis usefully describes when, where and how the U.S. can influence smaller and more vulnerable countries. From the weak state's perspective Western linkage is welcome, but it is also understood to be just steps away from infringing on national sovereignty and the right of countries to chart their own courses.

To complement this account of why competitive authoritarian countries go one way or another, it would be useful to explore the principal reasons why some states interfere in the politics of other states. In this account, a country like Russia is described as a 'black knight,' so presumably the U.S. and EU would be cast as white knights. But this characterization is overly simplistic and fails to distinguish the mixed motivations of the white knight, not all of which are benign. To highlight Western motives for the purpose of discussion and self-examination might contribute to fewer cases of democratization being abandoned in Africa. The same could apply to a critique of Chinese and Russian motives for intervening in other countries' domestic politics via, for example, the Belt and Road Initiative and the Wagner Group.

Returning to Levitsky and Way's *Foreign Affairs'* essay, the authors write that "In 2025, the United States ceased to be a full democracy in the way that Canada, Germany, or even Argentina are democracies." How so? Just as was shown in their 2010 book, nearly all of the governments examined were formally democratic, but nevertheless they were

> nondemocracies because constitutional rules were routinely subverted. Supreme Courts or constitutional courts were circumvented or trampled upon . . nominally independent electoral commissions were packed or emasculated . . . and term limits were violated or dismantled.

The Trump administration is following the same playbook, "To weaponize the state, elected autocrats must purge and then pack it." The purpose is not to lead the U.S. but to consolidate the power of Trump and his Republican Party by using intimidation and retribution to tilt the political playing field for long-term advantage. The authors note that U.S. history is filled with "examples of antidemocratic behavior" but are quick to add that "overtly authoritarian abuse largely disappeared in the United States after the civil rights reforms of the 1950s and 1960s and the post-Watergate reforms of the 1970s."

At this moment, Americans who oppose the authoritarian turn are advised to acknowledge that theirs is unquestionably an authoritarian regime in its ascendancy. At the same, they are reminded not lose faith that democratic resistance can stop and ultimately reverse the course of American authoritarianism. History has proven that authoritarianism can be rolled back. It's all in the will.

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Endnotes

(1) The list includes six countries from Eastern Europe (Slovakia, Romania, Macedonia, Albania, Serbia, Croatia), six countries from the former U.S.S.R. (Russia, Ukraine, Belarus, Georgia, Moldova, Armenia), six countries from the Americas (Mexico, Haiti, Dominican Republic, Guyana, Peru, Nicaragua), 14 countries from Africa (Zimbabwe, Mozambique, Madagascar, Botswana, Zambia, Cameroon, Malawi, Benin, Ghana, Senegal, Gabon, Mali, Kenya, Tanzania) and three countries from Asia (Cambodia, Malaysia, Taiwan).

Reviewing *Gulag* (February 2026)

In 2004, in the midst of America's War on Terror, Anne Applebaum's *Gulag* won the Pulitzer Prize for nonfiction. This was nearly forgotten history, everything now being relative to the Middle East and, in particular, al Qaeda and Saddam Hussein. Applebaum, a journalist and public historian, sneaked out a win with a history from the coldest, darkest days of the Cold War—quite remarkable since Stalin and his Gulag and Soviet dissidents like Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn and Andrei Sakharov were no longer news, and Alexei Navalny hadn't yet become known to America. By the turn of the century, the U.S.S.R. and Soviet Communism had decisively collapsed, and America had emerged by default as the solitary superpower.

For a short while, it did seem like the 'end of history,' with American democracy having surpassed or outlasted all rival political systems. For many, including this reviewer, the unimaginable end of the Cold War did arrive in their lifetimes. However, after a devastating attack on its homeland, America had found a new formidable enemy in political Islam. A new global war had to be fought. This is what Applebaum was up against with her 2003 *Gulag*. Looking back though, her book is not as irrelevant as one might think. In fact, she closes the book with these words: "This book was written because it almost certainly will happen again." "It" refers to "our ability to debase and destroy and dehumanize our fellow men," as during the 20th century tragedies of "the Gulag, the Holocaust, the Armenian massacre, the Nanking massacre, the Cultural Revolution, the Cambodian revolution, the Bosnian wars, among many others."

Reading this book a generation after its publication provides readers with an opportunity to revisit her warning. In 2024, she wrote *Autocracy, Inc*. in which she identifies a new global power struggle between liberal democracies and illiberal as well as

totalitarian political systems, Hungary being an example of an illiberal democracy and China an example of a present-day totalitarian regime. During the early part of the 21st century, talk of "the end of history" has been replaced by cautions that the death of liberal democracy is imminent. Applebaum, a vocal critic of U.S. President Trump and his vision for a new America, sees America careening towards the authoritarianism of its former enemies, Nazi Germany and the Stalinist U.S.S.R. Reading *Gulag* now gives the reader the benefit of hindsight to look for similarities between today's America and the evil genius driving the U.S.S.R during its murderous heyday.

In choosing to write about Stalin's Gulag, Applebaum implies that one of her purposes in choosing this subject is to raise (or reawaken) a general awareness of Stalin's evil. In her Introduction she writes that "to many people, the crimes of Stalin do not inspire the same visceral reaction as do the crimes of Hitler." Her objective is not so much to paint Stalin to be Hitler's equal in depravity and wickedness but to remind readers that what he did during his reign of terror must be remembered so that its recurrence, in whatever form, will not go unchallenged. Provoking a visceral response from the reader also seems to be part of what she had in mind.

Applebaum's previous histories of Russia/U.S.S.R. and Eastern Europe have been part of her effort to keep memories of 20th century horrors alive by revisiting state records and survivor stories. Her history of the Gulag is addressed to both past and new readers of Soviet history, and it is therefore a warning against forgetfulness and ignorance. Unbeknownst to Applebaum at the time, it also puts readers on high alert regarding the sort of state-managed amnesia one sees in Trump's America, e.g., with respect to the rewriting of Black American history—downplaying 400 years of slavery, the Civil Rights movement and ongoing anti-black racism.

Applebaum’s history is a history of the Gulag (more familiar to readers of Solzhenitsyn as the Gulag Archipelago), the system of prison camps in the Soviet Union for both criminals (thieves, rapists, murderers, etc.) and political prisoners (opposition party members, critics of Stalin and the U.S.S.R. and other such enemies of the people) spread across the gigantic Soviet Empire from the Baltic to the Pacific. More than half of her book is devoted to descriptions of life in the camps, and she focuses most on those in Northeastern Europe and Siberia—places nearly impossible for human habitation, places like the Vorkuta coal basin, the Norilsk nickel mines and the Kolyma gold mines.

Among Soviet historians, there are debates about the extent to which the Stalin’s Gulag was promoted chiefly to eliminate Stalin’s opponents or to create a system of ‘slave labourers’ to settle the empty north. For Applebaum, it doesn’t really matter as both were driving factors. She writes that Stalin's "obsessive interest in vast construction projects" and his “new program of extremely—almost hysterically—rapid industrialization" provided the camps with a strong economic rationale, whereas his use of slave labour for public works follows the precedent of Peter the Great, the famed architect (and forgotten enslaver) of the grandeur of St. Petersburg.

Applebaum’s work is based on state records that haven’t been destroyed and have been made available, but there remain large gaps in the history of the U.S.S.R. Unlike Germany, the U.S.S.R. was not conquered by foreign armies already mapping out war crimes charges, so for Russia, the excavation and preservation of secret state documents never acquired the same level of attention and urgency. Thus, former inmate memoirs are a primary source of information about the prison camps and they occupy a substantial portion of the book.(1)

The most compelling portion of the book is also the most uncomfortable to read. As I was reading, I marked chapters 7 (Arrest), 8 (Prison) and 9 (Transport) as being replete with singularly horrific accounts. This was the beginning of Applebaum's condensed history of the Soviet Gulag. It started with the arrest. In responding to her interlocutor's often-asked question, "What for?," Nadezhda Mandelstam answers, "What do you mean what for? It's time you understood that people are arrested for nothing!" Prison and transport were intermediate stages. The camps were the final destination, literally in the cases of millions. For what it is worth, Stalin's Gulag was not comprised of death camps on the scale of Nazi Germany's.(2) Stalin wanted his prisoners alive to work themselves to death, after which point replacements would be requisitioned. Nina Gagen-Torn, writing about the exceeding slow conveyance of prisoners by train—in cattle trains not passenger trains—to faraway places, speaks of the indifference of the guards on the train: "They didn't look at us as people. We were living cargo." And once in the camps, the prisoners were truly inanimate factors of production, which like machines wear out and have to be replaced—just entries to be recorded in the accounting ledgers.

While the camps were not death camps, they were concentration camps, and across the vast U.S.S.R., the camp regimen focused on dehumanizing and controlling the person: designating where he could and could not go (e.g., to ensure he didn't get shot in the 'death zone' by the guards in the watchtowers); dictating the times and durations for sleeping, working, bathing, eating and counting (prisoners were routinely counted multiple times in subzero temperatures while standing still for however long it took); and compelling him to work to the norms in backbreaking manual labour, where meeting the norm meant the difference between getting prison bread and cabbage soup or nothing at all.

Evgeniya Ginzburg, an intellectual and thus a political, writes of the boat trip along the Pacific Coast to Kolyma, where she first became acquainted with the criminal prisoners:

> They were the cream of the criminal world: murderers, sadists, adept at every kind of sexual perversion . . . without wasting any time they set about terrorizing and bullying the “ladies,” delighted to find that “enemies of the people” were creatures even more despised and outcast than themselves . . . They seized our bits of bread, snatched the last of our rags with our bundles, pushed us out of the places we had managed to find.

Vardam Shalamov writes of how quickly the human (machine) parts wore down:

> In order for a healthy young man, beginning his career at the gold-face in the clean, cold air, to turn into a “goner,” he needed only a period of twenty to thirty days of sixteen-hour workdays, without days off, coupled with systematic starvation, tattered clothes, nights in 60 degrees below zero of cold in a canvas tent full of holes.

Gustav Herling writes of what it means to learn to live “without pity:”

> At first he shares his bread with hunger-demented prisoners, leads the night-blind[3] on the way home from work, shouts for help when his neighbor in the forest has chopped off two fingers, and surreptitiously carries cans of soup and herring-heads to the mortuary.[4] After several weeks he realizes that his motives in all this are neither pure nor really disinterested, that he is following the egotistic injunctions of his brain and saving first of all himself. The camp, where prisoners live at the lowest level of humanity and follow their own brutal code of behavior toward others . . . How could he have supposed, back in

> prison, that a man can be so degraded as to arouse not compassion but only loathing and repugnance in his fellow prisoners?

In a brutally frank assessment of whether prisoners conducted themselves with unblemished humanity, Shalamov shoos away any praise for his having survived the camps and confesses (more than most of us would dare): “The camp was a great test of our moral strength, of our everyday morality, and 99 percent of us failed it.”

It wasn’t just the guards who tortured the prisoners. The camps were mixed with hard-core criminals as well as politicals, and the two did not mix well. There was, of course, murder, usually of politicals by criminals. And there was sexual violence even though men and women were supposed to be segregated. Herling describing a gang rape, writes that the victim “let out a short, throaty cry, full of tears and muffled by her skirt. A sleepy voice called from the watch-tower: ‘Come, come boys, what are you doing? Have you no shame?’ The eight men pulled the girl behind the latrines, and continued . . .”

And Herling again, writing of the anonymity of so much death and so many corpses that in winter the bodies had to be stacked like logs until the spring thaws opened the earth to receive the dead,

> We had no idea where the dead were buried, or whether, after a prisoner’s death, any kind of death certificate was ever written . . . The certainty that no one would ever learn of their death, that no one would ever know where they had been buried, was one of the prisoners’ greatest psychological torments

And Ginzburg whose prison career included cutting down trees in the Siberian north before luckily getting work in a camp nursery. But

what she witnessed there was the psychological horror of seeing children born to camp prisoners who had been so badly treated that many had not even learned to speak:

> Only certain of the four-year-olds could produce a few odd, unconnected words. Inarticulate howls, mimicry and blows were the main means of communication. “How can they be expected to speak? Who was there to teach them?” explained Anya [a co-worker] dispassionately. “In the infants’ group they spend their whole time just lying on their cots. Nobody will pick them up, even if they cry their lungs out. It’s not allowed, except to change wet diapers—when there are dry ones available, of course.”

And here Applebaum’s closing words demand our attention: “it almost certainly will happen again.”

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Endnotes

(1) Applebaum quotes from numerous sources but issues a special acknowledgement to the following on account of the extensive quotations from their writings: Varlam Shalamov (*Kolyma Tales*), Isaak Filshtinsky, Gustav Herling (*A World Apart*), Evgeniya Ginzburg (*Journey into the Whirlwind*), Lev Razgon (*True Stories*), Janusz Bardach (*Man Is Wolf to Man: Surviving Stalin’s Gulag*), Olga Adamova-Sliozberg (*My Journey*), Anatoly Zhigulin, Alexander Dolgun (*Alexander Dolgun’s Story: An American in the Gulag*) and Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn (*The Gulag Archipelago*, *First Circle* and *One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovich)*. No English translations are listed for Filshtinsky and Zhigulin.

(2) Applebaum writes that, “From 1939, it seems that Beria—with, presumably, Stalin behind him—no longer explicitly

intended the Gulag camps to be death camps, as some of them had been, in effect, in 1937 and 1938." However, for those familiar with Solzhenitsyn's prison writings, his tribute to Varlam Shalamov, a Kolyma camp survivor, contextualizes the extreme conditions and barbarous punishments in the northern camps:

> Shalamov's experience in the camps was longer and more bitter than my own, and I respectfully confess that to him and not me was it given to touch those depths of bestiality and despair toward which life in the camps dragged us all."

According to Applebaum, the three northern mining camps of Vorkuta (coal), Norilsk (nickel) and Kolyma (gold) were the harshest.

(3) This passage from Herling shows two things: first, how well the author depicts an awful reality of the camps, and second, how awful that reality is: "the night-blind, [walk] slowly through the zone in the early mornings and evenings, their hands fluttering in front of them."

(4) The camp mortuary, which Herling has elsewhere described as a bone shop or an ossuary, is the last stop before the grave. Here, prisoners who were barely alive and from whom no more work could be extracted were consigned until they were buried (or, if it was winter, stacked like timber until springtime).

Reviewing *The Lost Cause* (April 2026)

Recently, I came across a reference to Edward A. Pollard's 1867 American Civil War history, *The Lost Cause: A New Southern History of the War of the Confederates.* It was not a positive reference as it focused on Pollard's white supremacist views. For months I set it aside . . . indefinitely . . . but after reading Vasily Grossman's 1944 article 'The Hell of Treblinka' and his later novel *Everything Flows*, I thought it might be worthwhile to read another non-standard history of war,(1) this time about the American Civil War.

Pollard was an editor with the *Richmond Examiner* during the Civil War, and so he was at the centre of the latest news and information circulating in the Confederacy's capital. Although a staunch supporter of the Confederacy, he was highly critical of the administration of Confederate President Jefferson Davis for its inept management of the war. For Pollard, Richmond could be charged with losing the war, what with its class-based conscription policy that exempted those who could pay;(2) its incompetent management of foodstuffs and supplies for the military (shoes for the common foot soldier were a luxury); its interference with military planning; its failure to court European recognition of the Confederacy in Europe, especially from England and France; and its locating the capital within easy marching distance from the North. Richmond was attacked multiple times by Union forces during the war, and the area of Northern and Eastern Virginia around Richmond became the principal theatre of the war.(3)

Pollard's thesis, simply put, is the Confederate cause was a morally just cause. In order to justify this assertion, he is compelled to play up the political tyranny of the North (e.g., the radical abolitionists), greed and the agency of money driving the war effort (though he admits that it was on both sides), the culture(4) and chivalry of the

South (the legacy of the English cavaliers), the superiority of democracy in a federal system in which each member State is invested with a degree of sovereignty that limits the totalizing authority of a central government. And most importantly, he has to keep silent about the evils of slavery. So, for example, engaging in a 'whataboutist' critique of the North's accumulation of wealth from the Atlantic slave trade would be a tactical mistake.

Pollard's invocation of States' rights was simply a ruse to allow legalized slavery. The Southern slave States rationalized it in the extreme arguing that the U.S. Constitution of the day entitled States to exercise those powers not explicitly granted to the federal government. Since slavery was not banned in the Constitution and the federal government was not delegated the authority to regulate the practice, an opening was provided for slave owners to influence State legislators to enact pro-slavery laws on their behalf. In an age when political rights were race-based and gender-based, the notion of human rights was completely alien. Slavery was not morally abhorrent to the leaders of the Christian South. On the contrary, slavery became the vehicle by with the Southern States competed for power in Washington with the newly-industrializing Northern States. The North no longer relied on labour-intensive farming, and so it didn't need millions of slaves to plant and harvest the crops. The South, on the other hand, was fully agrarian, and it did require millions of slaves prior to the invention and deployment of mechanized farming.

My reading of the book is mostly but not wholly critical. For example, from the text, it can be inferred that the Civil War was waged over perceived inequities (between North and South) in political and economic power in the Union. However, that does not entail dismissing slavery as an attendant cause of the war. Quite the opposite: it is impossible for the history of the Civil War to ignore the slavery question in all of its aspects, as it was

fundamental to the political, economic and eventually military conflict between North and South. After all, it was slavery that created and sustained the aristocratic social structure of the South and enabled the Southern ruling elite to contest the dominance of the Northern elite. Unsurprisingly, Pollard elects to avoid class-based analysis, but the reader can readily surmise from the narrative that the ruling classes of the North and South sucked their workers and slaves into their power struggle, propagandizing, proselytizing and recruiting them. Of this he writes,

> The war spirit in either section was fed and stimulated, in a very great degree, by the profits which the heavy public expenditures brought to large classes of persons directly responsible for the war, and connected with its operations.

Nevertheless, Pollard is impressed by the “magnificent array” of Union and Confederate soldiers and their regimental colours facing off across the hills and valleys just prior to battle. And he is fairly obsessed with the details of the battles, exclaiming in admiration at the tactical brilliance of a Confederate general executing a perfect feint or flanking maneuver. Despite his enthusiasm for the strategic side of warmaking, he does not hold back from putting the reality of war on display. The following eye-witness report of the Battle of Fort Donelson early during the war paints a gruesome canvas of what the battlefield looks like by day’s end.

> “I could imagine,” says an eye-witness of the field of carnage, “nothing more terrible than the silent indications of agony that marked the features of the pale corpses which lay at every step. Though dead and rigid in every muscle, they still writhed, and seemed to turn to catch the passing breeze for a cooling breath. Staring eyes, gaping mouths, clenched hands, and strangely contracted limbs, seemingly drawn into the smallest compass, as if by a mighty effort to rend asunder some irresistible bond which

> held them down to the torture of which they died. One sat against a tree, and, with mouth and eyes wide open, looked up into the sky, as if to catch a glance at its fleeting spirit. Another clutched the branch of an overhanging tree, and hung half-suspended, as if in the death-pang he had raised himself partly from the ground; the other had grasped his faithful musket, and the compression of his mouth told of the determination which would have been fatal to a foe, had life ebbed a minute later. A third clung with both hands to a bayonet which was buried in the ground. Great numbers lay in heaps, just as the fire of the artillery mowed them down, mangling their forms into an almost undistinguishable mass."

But Pollard goes further and targets the North's methods of waging war as being beyond the pale. He gives several examples which if occurring today would appear to be war crimes, most notably General Philip Sheridan's campaign of terror through Virginia's Shenandoah Valley and General William T. Sherman's scorched-earth march through Georgia and then on through South Carolina. When Pollard speaks of the atrocities committed by Northern troops, he is saying nothing new. To his credit, Pollard does acknowledge the Union General George McClellan's conviction (and an unpopular one at that) that wars ought to be waged with restraint and in keeping with the "laws of civilized and Christian warfare." And doubtless, there were atrocities committed by soldiers from the South as well, but they would find no place in this book any more than would accounts of the abominations of slavery. What is shocking is that in such a brutal war, both North and South convinced themselves that they occupied the higher moral ground.

And then there is President Lincoln's (infamous) illegal suspension of the ancient right of *habeas corpus*, which smacks of the arrogation of presidential powers during wartime, a recurring theme of America's wars from the post-Civil War Indian wars, through the

World Wars, the wars in Vietnam, Iraq and Afghanistan up to and including the most recent wars against Iran and Venezuela. According to Pollard,

> At [sic] the North, there was no necessity for arbitrary arrests. The country was not invaded. The war was at a distance; and was offensive, not defensive. Except in portions of the Border States, the public sentiment was unanimous as against the South; opinions only differing as to the best means of reducing the distant “rebellion.” Yet a system of terrour was established, which could only have been warrantable at the South, and was held to be unnecessary even there.

In his conclusion, Pollard shows his hand. First, he acknowledges that on the questions of secession and slavery, the North won; the South lost. Reflecting on the end of slavery in America, he opines,

> That war closed on a spectacle of ruin, the greatest of modern times . . . their slave property taken away by a stroke of the pen; a pecuniary loss of two thousand millions of dollars involved in one single measure of spoliation—a penalty embraced in one edict, [the Emancipation Proclamation] in magnitude such as had seldom been exacted unless in wars synonymous with robberies.

This is the businessman’s ledger, the very antithesis of those grand principles of equality endorsed by America’s leaders in the Declaration of Independence in 1776.

> We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.

Pollard refuses to yield to these principles. In his clarion call to the future, he pronounces that “the war did not decide negro equality; it did not decide negro suffrage; it did not decide State Rights.” And that brings us to the 21st century where these three issues continue to divide Americans.

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Endnotes

(1) Grossman’s early writings as a Soviet war correspondent were favourably received. However, some of the views he expressed in *Stalingrad* were censored and *Everything Flows* (whose Chapter 14 graphically depicts the Ukrainian Holodomor) was only published after the introduction of *glasnost* by Mikhail Gorbachev. Associated with Soviet socialist realism, his writings have not been widely promoted in the U.S. Curiously though, his nonfictional account of Treblinka was reportedly included in the prosecution’s evidence at Nuremburg.

(2) In Richmond, it was said, irreverently, that it is “easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter Camp Lee.”

(3) Initially, the Confederate capital was Montgomery, Alabama, which was much further back from the front lines of battle.

(4) One particularly interesting feature of the standard of English spelling used by Pollard is the marked refusal to incorporate the simplified American spelling introduced by the (Northern) lexicographer, Noah Webster. Words like ‘centre’ and ‘honour’ reveal their French roots unlike the Americanized ‘center’ and ‘honor.’ This is vivid illustration of the South’s adamant refusal to accept cultural (linguistic) impositions from the North.

The authors, Michael Schaeffer Omer-Man and Sarah Leah Whitson, are both journalists and human rights advocates with close ties to DAWN (Democracy for the Arab World Now), a Washington-based nonprofit organization that promotes democracy, human rights, and political reform in the Middle East and North Africa. DAWN was founded by Jamal Kashoggi whose work as a journalist and human rights activist ended abruptly with his gruesome assassination, allegedly directed by Mohammed bin Salman (MBS), the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia, in 2018. Omer-Man is a former editor with *+972 Magazine* and before that with the *Jerusalem Post*. Whitson is a human rights lawyer who prior to being the Executive Director of DAWN was the Executive Director of Human Rights Watch's Middle East and North Africa Division.

Omer-Man's and Whitson's book, *Apartheid to Democracy: A Blueprint for Peace in Israel-Palestine*, published in 2025, is an attempt to offer an alternative to the Oslo process, which they argue has been "negotiated under the skewed and coercive power dynamics of permanent military occupation" and was therefore "no longer a relevant framework for resolving the situation in Israel-Palestine," particularly in light of the Gaza War. The authors present a detailed, preliminary blueprint with

> practical steps to transform an undemocratic, de facto one-state reality into a democratic, rights-respecting regime with equality for all peoples under its control and to afford both Jewish Israelis and Palestinians the opportunity to exercise self-determination in one, two, or more states if they choose.

Their thesis is simple, straightforward and, for some, controversial. They propose a three-year Transition under a caretaker

government broadly representative of a conflicted Israel-Palestine, what the authors refer to in their book as the Territory.(1) During the Transition, the Israeli occupation of the OPT, the Occupied Palestinian Territory,(2) is to end and the system of apartheid that allocates differential rights based on ethnic and religious identity markers is also to be terminated.

What is different about their proposal is that governance issues are to be postponed until the rights issues associated with the occupation and apartheid have been resolved during the Transition phase. It is in the post-Transition phase that the authors believe the power asymmetries established and maintained by occupation and apartheid will give all peoples of the Territory a reasonable opportunity to exercise their democratic preference for the type of new state they will be governed by—one state, two state, federation, confederation or consociation. What is non-negotiable are the democratic features of universal suffrage and equality before the law, where the Guiding Principles of the Transition will re-fashion the Basic Laws so that they “enshrine democracy and equality.”

In the Oslo process and previous peace efforts, the issues of occupation and apartheid have been deferred until after peace negotiations, this being the preferred strategy of Israel and the U.S. The authors argue that with military occupation and apartheid intact, the bargaining position of Palestinians is unfairly and substantially weakened. More importantly, the denial/curtailment of Palestinian freedom under the systems of military occupation and apartheid puts Palestinians in the awkward position of having to negotiate for fundamental human rights. Expect strong resistance from Israel and the U.S. to the authors’ prioritization of ending the occupation and apartheid.

To the question, ‘Why now?’ In their book, the authors cite the opportunity provided by the confluence of many significant developments since the Hamas massacre on October 7th and the ensuing war against Gaza by Israel aided financially, militarily and politically by the U.S. The following are consequential features of the political landscape that the authors have considered in deciding to submit their Blueprint for discussion:

- South Africa’s case before the International Court of Justice (ICJ) charging Israel with genocide in the Gaza Strip (December 2023)
- The ICJ’s Advisory Opinion on the illegality of Israel’s military occupation and its system of apartheid (July 2024)
- The International Criminal Court’s (ICC) arrest warrant for Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and former Minister of Defense, Yoav Gallant, on charges of war crimes committed during the Gaza War (November 2024)
- The addition of Canada, France, the U.K., Portugal and Australia to the list of United Nations (UN) member states officially recognizing the State of Palestine at the opening of 80th session of the UN General Assembly (September 2025).
- The positive examples of South Africa (end of apartheid, 1994) and Northern Ireland (end of The Troubles, 1998), each with long histories of conflict and each once written off as hopeless cases.

For the authors, it is the ICJ's 2024 Advisory Opinion that is key for the post-Oslo world. As the ICJ’s opinion demands that Israel end its 'crimes,' i.e., its refusal to accept the rules and determinations of international law, it forms the basis for the principal thesis of the Blueprint, viz., that Israel must end its illegal occupation of the OPT and its apartheid regime throughout the Territory before any peace and governance negotiations can have any meaning.

Whether the time is finally ripe for a permanent end to occupation and apartheid and the wars and violence in the Territory remains to be seen. Jewish supremacy, (uncompromising Zionism) and unconditional U.S. support(3) coupled with the absence of a neutral great power(4) are the principal obstacles that the Blueprint faces, though extremists on both sides can be expected to sabotage any attempt to bring lasting peace to the Territory.

Furthermore, Israel remains committed to total victory, i.e., domination over the Palestinians, so ending military occupation and apartheid are non-starters. For Jews, the very terms ‘occupation' and ‘apartheid) are contested. At issue for Jews is a bona fide sense of insecurity, and Jewish supremacy (through Zionism) is the only sure way for Jews to feel safe in their homeland. On the Palestinian side, the leadership is not only weak but it is also corrupt, and this leaves the Palestinian people with few good reasons to trust the Jewish state or their own leaders.

I see no urgent reasons for Israel to buy into the Blueprint. Israel has long been a pariah state in the eyes of much of the world—but not that part of the world that matters (North America and Europe)—and yet it has not just survived but thrived. Israel is not interested in winning a popularity contest in the UN General Assembly, not when it commands a permanent veto in the UN Security Council. U.S. support is unshakable for a number of reasons—geopolitical, religious, economic, cultural and racial. European support is fairly reliable for the same reasons. Germany is especially indebted to the Jewish state on account of it having perpetrated the Holocaust and got off easy. Much of Europe is also indebted to Israel for taking their Jews after World War II.

From a moral standpoint, the Blueprint is compelling, but not compelling enough for those in power to willingly cede power. At

one point, the authors stumble over the one thing that could change the power balance—violent instability. Thus, the authors write

> In Israel-Palestine, the levels of political violence experienced by Palestinians, particularly during the ongoing war in Gaza, may well have reached a level where they are prepared to accept a new alternative. Jewish Israelis have not reached a point where their personal experience of violence has led them to seriously consider alternative political visions, but continued war, disorder, and insecurity may.

In other words, Israel would only consider following international norms if the state breaks down and can no longer protect Jews. A mass exodus of wealth and human capital would likely flow from Israel. But before the collapse of the Israeli state, a totalitarian regime would probably emerge, ruthlessly enforcing unfreedom beyond anything imaginable even in a land so long condemned to military occupation and apartheid.

The following reads like a script for the only way the authors' Blueprint vision could become reality.

> [A] willingness to consider an alternative to occupation and apartheid rule can emerge if Israelis find themselves embroiled in domestic upheaval and violence sufficient to disturb their own security and stability and international sanctions and isolation that heighten their insecurity and instability. For that to represent a moment of "ripeness," it will require Jewish Israelis to reimagine and expand their thinking to include manifestations of national self-determination that are not mutually exclusive to Palestinian national self-determination. Jewish Israelis will likely only start to question that belief if they come to the conclusion

that the Jewish state is no longer able to provide security, stability, and prosperity for Jews.

Despite the number and magnitude of the challenges that the Blueprint faces, the authors have the remarkable tenacity and optimism to detail an articulate and well-thought-out draft of a solution that may well contribute to something positive. Two crucial final thoughts stressed by the authors are: first, that whatever solution emerges it must be a local solution and not one imposed (mandated) from outside and second, that active and meaningful engagement from both Jews and Palestinians is a sine qua non for success.

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Endnotes

(1) Territory, as used by authors, refers to Israel-Palestine or "all of the area between the Mediterranean Sea and the Jordan River, including Israel, the West Bank including East Jerusalem, and the Gaza Strip".

(2) OPT, for the authors, applies to "all of the Palestinian territories that Israel captured Territory (OPT) and occupied in June 1967 (the West Bank including East Jerusalem, and the Gaza Strip), which today comprise the State of Palestine."

(3) The U.S. is a source of unconditional support—military, economic and diplomatic for Jewish state. "The US has effectively shielded Israel from accountability and granted it unparalleled military and political protection, allowing it to pursue its apartheid, occupation, and the ongoing war in Gaza with impunity." Furthermore, as its protector, the umbrella of U.S. exceptionalism extends to Israel. Thus, Israel has U.S. support when it refuses to be encumbered by

international legal restrictions on its absolute sovereignty, e.g., with respect to the UN, the ICJ and the ICC.

(4) The Israel-Palestine conflict can be traced to the persecution of Jews in Europe, of which Germany's Holocaust is by far the worst atrocity. The argument can be made that Germany has escaped with light punishment for its crimes, while the Palestinians have become the surrogate for the full hatred, fury and retribution of a people so severely traumatized and ultimately displaced. Palestinians have paid in blood and the loss of their land. Germany has paid only in money and a promise of unequivocal support for the Jewish state. Meanwhile, Germany is responsible for two genocides in the 20th century (one in Europe and one in Africa). There are moral imperatives that would make Germany the perfect candidate to act as neutral great power, but the political concept of *Staatsräson* would need to be revisited to be consistent with Germany's new role as an honest peace broker in Israel-Palestine.

NB: these are the reviewer's reflections and ought not to be attributed to the authors.

This is a collection of fiction (13 short-short stories) and nonfiction (12 book commentaries).

It follows some of the themes explored in my last three books: *The End of the Human Era*, *eclipsed*, and *Artifacts of a Troubled and Troublesome Species*.

About the Author

Peter McMillan lives with his wife and Lottie, their flat-coated retriever, on the northwest shore of Lake Ontario, and in addition to writing he teaches English.

